

Block**4****INDIA 'S TRYST WITH DIGITAL AGE**

UNIT 12**Internet and Marginalized Sections**

UNIT 13**Participatory Online Media**

UNIT 14**Online Activism**

UNIT 15**ICT for ODL**



UNIT 12 INTERNET AND MARGINALIZED SECTIONS

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12.0 INTRODUCTION

Internet has become a part of social life. From the essential yet limited scope of military operations to two-way communication, the Internet at Web 2.0 has covered almost all terrestrial areas in terms of reach. It is rapidly increasing its access to mobile economic technology. From emailing to content-publishing, the Internet has all the means - interpersonal communication to mass communication. Along with convergence, it is being utilised for socio-political awareness, advocacy, and mobilisation, cyber media activism, and it also provides an 'alternative' to the marginalised sections of the society. In the changing media culture, the Internet drives the voices of the voiceless to become a part of the mainstream. Interestingly, the Internet is a medium of direct communication at the mass level. Unlike other 'one-way' mainstream media, the Internet has immense potential and a significant role in creating a stage for inclusive governance with participation of all and thus, the inclusion of all sections of mainstream society against marginalisation.

This Unit, we shall discuss the concept of marginalisation; various digital media platforms and emerging patterns of communication processes, and their role in the representation of the marginalised section of the society.

12.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- understand the process of marginalisation and the nature and characteristics of marginalised sections of the society;
- describe the strengths and limitations of digital media platforms with a conceptual understanding of their forms and media;
- understand various digital programmes in order to analyse the content of Internet platforms;
- discuss a few inspiring cases of content production in order to create a level playing field; and
- participate and promote community engagement on the Internet towards mainstreaming with content production and sharing processes.

12.2 UNDERSTANDING MARGINALISATION AND THE MARGINALISED

The term marginalised is derived from the word 'margin' which means something at the periphery or fringe. It is an identity resulting from the process of marginalisation. We can understand through the process with the relative concepts of 'exclusion and inclusion'. While social inclusion makes people or individuals participate in the social-economic-political activities and provides a sense of importance, exclusion makes them deprived of it.

The marginalised groups or individuals may lack reach and easy access to various socio-economic resources such as food, health, education, employment, social security, etc. Various measurement indexes, such as the Human Development Index (HDI), Multidimensional based Poverty Index (MPI), have been developed by global agencies that look at marginalised sections based on various parameters. According to Carolyn Kagan and Mark H. Burton (2005) with "Little control over lives and resources, marginalised may become stigmatised and are often at the receiving end of negative public attitudes." The process thus results in the socio-psychological effects of being 'not important'. Because of the feeling of alienation, people/ individuals feel themselves as 'marginalised' with 'no voice'.

The marginalisation also means being in 'position of powerlessness' in the political process. Here, the terms 'reach and access' and 'social exclusion' are seen in power relationships. Thus, the process includes "Oppression, exclusion, vulnerability, or discrimination. [It] is the idea of identity [given] by others in the interest of the dominant groups in society" (Kagan and Burton: 2005). In a condition of social exclusion, the marginalised "Lack effective participation in key activities or benefits of the society in which they live" (Razer et al. as cited in Mowat, J. G.: 2015) due to the "Barriers

that block the attainment of livelihoods, human development and equal citizenship” (Alakhunova et al.:2015).

Thus, if we take the degree of ‘access’ ‘inclusion’ and ‘participation’ of groups or individuals in socio-economic-political decision-making as indicators of the process of marginalisation, the concept of marginalised as an ‘identity’ is “a social construct - different in time and space” (Sharma, R.:2018) and comes in layers. It may be based on the economic-political exclusion and/or social inequality, “Having ‘powerful, negative impacts’ Having on [a person’s] everyday life” (Pachankis as cited in Sharma: 2018). Madsen (2006) expounds marginalisation at three different levels, i.e. “The approach to the individual; his social and cultural conditions; and the complex interplay between people and their social environment” (cited in StorØ, J.:2013). Therefore, “marginalised” is contextual, situational, and relational. For instance, there are marginalised individuals within dominant groups and dominant individuals within the marginalised communities. Crime-victims (both, men and women), patients without health-facilities, children without education, and “All those struggling for a day-to-day decent life are marginalised despite their caste/religion affiliations” (Sharma: 2018). Similarly, “As life cycle stages change, risk of marginalisation increases or decreases” (Kagan and Burton: 2005).

This means that there needs to be a continuous effort to locate and remove the chances of marginalisation in a full circle and to create conditions for mainstreaming by increasing the chances of participation of all in the total socio-economic-political spheres. The Internet certainly provides us with a platform for networking in this direction.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note:1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What does it mean to be marginalised?

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2. List four measurement indexes that identify marginalisation.

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3. 'Marginalised' is not a fixed identity. Discuss the statement with an example of life cycle stages.

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12.3 DIGITAL MEDIA PLATFORMS: CONCEPTUAL UNDERSTANDING

Essentially digital technology is seen in three-forms, "Artefacts or devices, activities and practices, social arrangements or organisational forms" (Lievrou, L. and S. Livingstone: 2006) and also "A set of social relations which incorporate the use of technologies with various results" (Miller, V.:2011) within the 'information society.' It is a medium - a 'connection' or "interface (system, device, or technology) that human beings use to communicate with each other" (Panikkar, A.:2007). However, the question is the Internet a medium only for the egalitarian society? Or, does it push the social sector towards a new form of marginalisation where 'technical' access defines participation? These pertinent questions are discussed in this section to explore the theoretical understanding of Internet-based platforms as form and medium.

12.3.1 Production, Mediation, and Participation

From voice-command, audio-video recording to ease of uploading the content, Internet-based digital devices have the flexibility of usage. Today, the Internet is reaching the marginalised segments of the society to a large extent if not all. Interestingly, 'consumable media content' like videos, text messages' GIFs, etc. is being created and shared on social media sites such as Facebook, WhatsApp, YouTube, and taking the unheard voices to the rest of the world.

However, media production depends on specific technical aspects. For example, to get noticed by the authorities and social mainstream, the content produced by the marginalised has to be in circulation unless and until it reaches the desired effect. However, in the competitive world of the Internet, only the 'entertaining' content remains alive. Here, we have to take notice of what Steve Hill and Paul Bradshaw (2018) have said about "native content," "They needed to find out what content worked best in attracting and retaining audiences on this new medium." In this process, they mention the challenges of resource allocation for multi-platform visibility of content and also to remind us of the situation, "If a change in a social platform's algorithms leads to a publisher's content becoming less visible to users, then viewers are going to drop" (Hill and Bradshaw:2018).

Mediation is a complex process, where one entity represents the whole body. Often such narratives take extreme shapes with opposing interpretations and result in “the symbolic frontiers between ‘us’ and ‘them’” (Orgad, S.:2012). Though the process of mediation on the Internet ought to be different from other media that work ‘one-way,’ ‘one person’s narrative,’ yet even on two-way media platforms provided by the Internet, they are more or less the same due to lack of technical accessibilities as discussed above. In the absence of authentic content, the severe issues either remain hidden or take a distorted shape of ‘entertainment’.

Therefore, we need a ‘bottom-up approach,’ “As it provides further evidence that the disadvantaged are in the best position to know their own needs” (Alakhunova et al.: 2015). With “bottom-up planning and participation,” individuals, as part of marginalised sections, participate in content production and consumption that reflects their actual voices and language, their own concerns and conditions, issues of their development and governance, their mobilisation and participation, and importantly their knowledge, time and space (Slater, D.: 2013).

12.3.2 Network Embeddedness and Heterogeneity

Media practices are embedded in the technology they use. This is also true for Internet-based media. It directs our minds, body, and thus, social relations and worldview. For example, the social imagery attached to the mobile phone you use, the Internet-based work you perform, like - clicking pictures, chatting with friends, ‘browsing’, and exploring new relationships on Social Networking Sites (SNSs) - all are seen with set practices. Ashok Panikkar (2007) asserts, “Human beings do not merely ‘use’ machines; they immerse themselves in the ‘system’ that the machine brings with it.” This leads to the ‘controlled/embedded’ use of machines, sometimes, against the benefits to marginalised sections compromising their own knowledge-sets. Don Slater (2013) cites the example of the ‘North-South’ divide to explain the domination of ‘globally marginalised communities’ by the narratives of ‘transformation into an information society’. We live in a society where “the social is itself mediated” by the Internet. Thus, the media constitute social processes and realities that are ‘mediated’ and embedded with certain types of fixed visibilities to generate the effect.

Embeddedness plays a role when the issues and events are constructed in a formulaic manner, like - traditional media giving no space for the native content. For example, webcasts of traditional news formats, films, and TV series or visual stimulation on small screens attract more viewers than any story without it and leading to the embedded process of filter-based selection of content.

There is another technical embeddedness as well. For example, ‘virtual communities’ are formed only when people carry on the public discussion over a period of time through the intellectual and social organisation. Generally, those are the people of a particular ideology who have access to the Internet (Rheingold: 1993; Whitley: 2000; Wilfred: 2007). Another problem is the users’ data being analysed for marketing. For example,

“Facebook’s Instant Articles format allows publishers to embed ‘in-house analytics tools or third-party measurement services’” (Facebook for Developers, as cited in Hill and Bradshaw: 2019).

Nevertheless, if one understands the process of embeddedness, one can easily use the same technology as emancipatory media. Attributes like hybridism, hyper-textuality with the possibility of multimedia expansion (interconnectedness of information), and content-creativity enhance the heterogeneity. However, this will require a consistent dialogue coming from the marginalised sections/individuals. For example, content can be added and edited continuously on open websites such as Wikipedia. Blogs and video blogs can be made for the expansion of the viewer and heterogeneity in worldview.

12.3.3 Cyberoptimism vs. Cyberpessimism

While cyberoptimism celebrates the role of the Internet as a ‘free, interactive, democratising’ medium; cyberpessimism sees it with scepticism. Manuel Castells and Gustavo Cardoso (2006) view the Internet as the catalyst of the “structural transformation.” They find the “new technological paradigm” as interacting and working “according to the needs, values and interests of the users” (cited in Narayan, S.S., and Narayan, S.: 2016). In such a decentralised ‘network society,’ the marginalities mitigate with the expansion of communication access to individuals through various means like mobile phones and personal computers. Broader participation of individuals/sections changes the relationship matrix and thus paves the way for the emancipation of castes, genders, classes, and all at the margins. Shani Orgad (2012) observes the Internet to be a “More flexible and participatory communicative platform to cultivate intimacy at a distance on an ongoing, long-term basis,” for instance, long-term “reciprocal” relationship between bloggers/You Tubers and their audiences. The Internet-based content representing local issues/cultures often offers action-driven dialogue. It “Can help to enhance recognition and understanding of difference, and contribute to nourishing a richer and more complex global imagination” (Orgad: 2012). However, it ends in less impact due to lack of consistency, depth, completeness, and interest.

Conversely, scholars cite problems, such as anonymity of sources, doctored content posted for political agenda and propaganda, ‘fictionality’ of the virtual world that aggravate marginalisation. Such content on the Internet becomes the cause of riots, spatial disturbances, child/women trafficking, and abuse. The blurriness between real and virtual gives way to the ‘instable order’ of ‘liquid times’ (Appadurai, A.:1996; Bauman, Z.:2007). Shani Orgad (2012) also highlights the problem of “exposure to multiple storytellers” showing opposing/contestable accounts of the same reality that can confuse meaning-making, i.e. which account of reality to believe in? Don Slater (2013) cites an example of how Internet-based content has enlarged the rural-urban divide by representing only the “urban modernity.”

12.3.4 Digital Divide to Digital Citizenship

Based on the idea of ‘lack of access’ to the ICT and e-resources, the concept of the digital divide itself is a part of marginalisation. The expanded theory of the digital divide includes subtle-unidentifiable ‘multiple deprivations’ in terms of the quality of access with the availability of the Internet. It includes the ease of full access; for example, if an individual accessing the information cannot write an email, it cannot be called ‘full access to the Internet’.

According to the Internet & Mobile Association of India (IAMAI) and Nielsen report, with mobile telephony, India has 10% more Internet users in rural areas than in urban cities as of November 2019 with 227 million active Internet users (TOI, May 6, 2020). This can be marked as a paradigm shift mitigating the ‘urban-rural digital divide’. The Internet available in vernacular languages over voice command became a path breaker in this direction. The move resulted in increased interactivity and participation in e-governance. With a broader knowledge base in User-Generated Content (UGC), people are raising awareness on social media to make the authorities aware of the situation in almost every sector of governance like health, education, public distribution systems (PDS), farming sector, etc. Marginalised sections/individuals and other stakeholders are engaging in dialogue for governance as never before. Andre Lemos and Julio Valentim (2007) calls this “telematics culture with new practices of sociability” as part of an inclusive information society with “connectedness” (see also, Giddens, A: 1991; Castells, M.:2000). However, Internet accessibility is still lagging far behind the marginalised individuals/sections based on gender and class.

The qualitative assessment also questions the type of content consumed - whether the content is useful in bringing about social change. Ashok Panikkar (2007) explains the same in terms of news content that “does not allow for the creation of nuanced and analytical information,” and discussions turn into debates. Here, if the content is ‘manufactured’ only by a few, it will remain controlled by similar traditional structures. Therefore, the question arises as to who controls the system and ‘activity’ (Selwyn, N.:2004). The problems of spectrum distribution, free Wi-fi and net (Weinberger: 2003; Press, L.: 2003 cited in Lemos and Valentim: 2007), powerful narratives, skewed consumption pattern towards entertainment, and lack of content production by the marginalised for severe engagement of the society/governments remain the areas of concern in order to bring the ‘digital citizenship’ to all. Don Slater states (2013), “Access to a network means for producing, processing and circulating information.”

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. List five elements of the Internet.

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2. What does heterogeneity mean? List your suggestions to increase online heterogeneity?

3. Explain net neutrality. How does it contribute to 'digital citizenship'?

12.4 REPRESENTATIONS AND PRESENTATIONS

Media representations are the mediated presentations of social realities. Thus, the media content 're-presents' some of the other social aspects based on narratives they form. All media content, including written and visual content, through which we make meaning/sense of those represented is called text. The study of representations becomes essential since they do not come with a single meaning. The same event can have multiple meanings and perspectives, sometimes "stereotypes" and sometimes conflicting with "binary oppositions" (Barthes, R.:1977; Hall, S.:1997).

The process becomes more complicated when it comes to representations on the Internet. Here, the responsive text itself becomes a part of the media content. Although, essentially it is seen as 'presentations' or "self presentations," it becomes a "public text" (Illouz, E.:2007) in order to make a 'general representation'. Whether such a text represents the acceptance of 'difference/otherness' in the case of marginalised sections with intimacy, is a matter of inquiry.

12.4.1 Unconventional Forms

As representations are perspectives or "frames of understanding" (Hall: 1997), the mainstream media is often blamed for supporting only the dominant frame by either excluding or misrepresenting the marginalised. The Marxists and political-economic theorists have this view. Recently, with

more “intensive” communication flow, “extensive” networking, and “less controllable” visibility coming from all over on the Internet, the representation is not coming from top to bottom anymore (Thompson:2005 cited in Orgad:2012). Therefore, the Internet is being investigated to study the unconventional forms of representations where local social identities are being studied to know the differences and processes of marginalisation on a global scale.

Microblogging/Blogging/Video-blogging: Although the personal perspectives in the form of articles were always a part of traditional media, it became an integral part of social media as - blogs, Vlogs, and microblogs. Unlike traditional media, the Internet provides a free platform to all ‘private persons’ for publishing a blog in a global environment. While the previous is known for formal structure and ‘authority,’ blogs and microblogs on the Internet are non-formal - an innovative form of fact-fiction-drama documentary-commentary-all in “public mediated realm” (Orgad: 2012). Being the ‘legitimate alternative text,’ this content influences the traditional media (Woodly: 2008; Singer: 2014; Srivastava and Roy: 2016). However, the open gateways do not guarantee the participation of marginalised voices. Today, when we get our worldview through the Internet converging the traditional forms of media, we cannot forget that the blogs are essentially the personal accounts and can trap us in ‘manipulated representations’ especially in the absence of the ‘fact-checking’ tools (Silverstone:2007; Orgad:2012).

Gaming: Online games provide a fine example of the narrative construct based on technology and social structures (Murray, H.:1997). Close observation tells us how symbolically they form or take the path of personal stories, experiences, and life-cycles based in real-time and situations. Panikkar (2007) emphasises the role of carefully designed gaming ecosystems as “The furious pace at which information is coded and transmitted has the virtue of making information generation and communication far more democratic. This can help hitherto powerless groups level the playing field as far as their capacity to reach and influence broader audiences.”

Animation: On digital platforms, as a “sophisticated and flexible medium,” animation provides the filmmakers/content creators with the freedom of creativity (Wells, P.:1998). According to Mirium Harris, Lily Husbands, and Paul Taberham (2019), with more ‘experiments’ in animation online, an expansion in broader perspectives is expected. The power of animation lies in the fact that it calls for the total attention of the viewer, hence impacts their sensibilities immensely. Recently, with the use of 2D/3D computer animation, filmmakers have been experimenting with unconventional plots to touch upon the lives of the marginalised with individual narratives. Most such films are accessible freely on the Internet.

Similarly, there are unconventional forms such as memes. This “userdriven imitation and remixing” practice is continuously occupying the space online (Shifman, L: 2014). These simulating-stimulating ecosystems call upon audiences for immersion and therefore, are an effective medium to highlight

the conditions/issues concerning the marginalised. Indeed, genuine participation is the key.

12.4.2 Understanding the Language of the Internet

The Internet is a platform to access and create the 'new' content along with the existing content of traditional 'mainstream' media. Since the representations are 'mediated,' they are 'produced' in one perspective rather than in entirety. For example, the Barthesian concept of the simulacrum or 'representation through filters'. Similarly, various scholars claim that reality does not exist in one form, it is contextual and hence, open to multiple interpretations (Derrida: 1970; Barthes: 1973; Baudrillard: 1991; Hall: 1997). So, in order to understand the representation of 'multiple social realities' on the Internet, we have to read the content as text. The text is read for media processes such as –

- *Framing and priming*: Positioning of subject/stories in an intended way so that it may be understood in a particular way.
- *Labelling and stereotyping*: Presenting the subject/event with one particular 'fixed' perspective.
- *De-legitimisation and ex-nomination*: While de-legitimisation constructs the categories of groups to exclude them from society, the process of ex-nomination 'un-name' the dominating groups to "naturalise" their domination in society.
- *Intertextuality*: Cross-referencing of the conventions and visual styles in media content.

With this, the comments/responses and posts on the Internet create the part of discourse as supplementary/complementary to the mainstream content. Whether it really makes a mark as 'mainstream' content to represent the marginalised section is another question. Is there any impact of local content on a large scale? On SNSs like Facebook, Twitter performance is counted on two key factors - "speed and engagement time" (Hill and Bradshaw: 2019). With this, the impact of the online content can be called as "change of the second order" where 'revolution' passes at a pace (Radhakrishnan, R.:2007). Thus, the 'medium' transforms representations into the 'post representational state'. Immersion of this type establishes the dominance of the medium over the message and sometimes takes us far away from reality. "They give expression to - and also diminish - our consciousness" (Radhakrishnan: 2007).

Machine-driven language is also analysed quantitatively for representation with the use of software and programmes such as Google Analytics that is one of the popular websites of statistics services. It tracks and measures online traffic to learn patterns. However, the data-mining programmes, descriptive mapping of densities, or social network analysis such as Ncapture, R Programming, or Word Cloud do not tell us about the nature of the representation nor the "personal information field" as constituted online (Srivathsan, A.:2007). Moreover, data networking through forwards, shares,

likes, viral videos, and hashtags cannot guarantee representation of marginalised sections, since ideological processes are embedded or hidden. For example, computer-generated images through mathematical processing to create ‘virtual/simulated reality’; or, Peer-to-Peer (P2P) file-sharing without being detected. Qualitative data analysis software like Nvivo is now being developed to analyse online content.

Activity-1

Take any animation film available online. Observe it and analyse the representation of class in it.

Activity-2

Explore the content of any social media platform of your choice on the problem of migrant workers. Analyse-it for sources, the structure of the content and textual elements and see what relationship you draw between the source and the text.

12.5 INTERNET AND MARGINALISED SECTIONS: CASE STUDIES

Representations on the Internet involve ‘need-based’ consumption and creation of representations as well as self-presentations/representations and also, the ‘politics’ of the same. Through user-friendly technology interface, the marginalised sections, the State and other stakeholders participate in online representations for - free access to information and expression and better access to governance.

12.5.1 Use of the Internet by the State

The State promotes affirmative actions for ‘inclusion’. The Internet is turning out to be a frontrunner in the State-run endeavours to reach and represent the marginalised sections, for the dissemination of need-based content and promotion of e-governance. We are analysing two sectors here - Women and Child Welfare; and, Social Justice and Empowerment, to assess the structure, nature, and purpose of online content.

The media content of the Ministry of Women and Child Development is multimedia-based. The website contains YouTube videos depicting the positive stories of women-empowerment from the country. These women represent the idea of economic empowerment through the formation of various Self-Help Groups (SHGs) in remote areas. They share their experience of gaining mainstreaming by linking their skills rooted in tribal/rural art with modern practices and government schemes. Similar videos also showcase the ‘voices’ of children from the marginalised areas.

Some promotional videos creating awareness towards various government schemes such as - Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, Mudra Yojana, Ujjvala Yojana, etc., are run on the YouTube channel of the Ministry with 13.4 thousand subscribers (as of May 2020). However, it is a ‘single way

platform' and not open for comments. The feedback is taken through emails. Technically, the content is accessible to visitors with visual impairment on 'screen reader access' pathways. The website also shares visitors' analytics that shows visitors' statistics, referrer, browser, and devices used to access information such as personal computers, smartphones, tablets, and others. The Women and Child Development Department under the Delhi Government has a showcase of the schemes on the homepage of the website. The website is full of hyperlinks, however, and the multimedia is not used in the way the other website does.

The website of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment provides visual representations of the beneficiaries under various schemes. A section of the text states the 'constitutional provisions' and 'sector overview' for awareness on 'exercising the civil rights'. The website provides easy access to various schemes of the ministry and its applications. There is one section for comments/suggestions/feedback on policy issues; for example, the invited suggestions on Draft on "the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Rules, 2020." However, again, the gateway for two-way communication for consistent engagement is missing.

However, all the above attempts show that the government is striving to make internet-based content more accessible to the marginalised sections. The initiative of Vikaspedia - as part of the India Development Gateway (InDG) is another example. The portal showcases the impact stories and links the marginalised with e-governance.

12.5.2 Community Engagement on the Internet for Social Change

The arena of community media has become much broader with the addition of the Internet. The medium is a great source to increase outreach through converging technology and transforming the content into a 'multimedia' format. We find fine instances of civil society and non-governmental organisations led community-based newspapers and participatory video practices going for their online editions. For example, the newspaper Khabar Lahariya published by the rural communities of Bundelkhand. This newspaper is also published on a portal in a multimedia format including YouTube videos. This is being widely appreciated for being an 'alternative voice,' sensitising, and mainstreaming the people. Similarly, with the local engagement of the children in the age group of 15-18 years from marginalised tribal communities of northern Chhattisgarh, a UNICEF initiative - Sangwari Khabariya uses the medium of participatory videos to bring about social change in the society. These children run their YouTube channel to post short news stories.

Based on "democratic communication rights" through availability and access to information, media competency, dialogue, and privacy (Nieminen, H.:2018), the communities also directly participate in media practices to bring about social change. This has become a possibility, mainly due to easy access to 'user-friendly' mobile technology and government support. The rural community of Goner village in Rajasthan sets an example. The village

holds the advantage of being located in the vicinity of Jaipur. With physical connectivity, the village has also adopted the technical connectivity online, and almost every household is well connected with the Gram Panchayat and local governance through social networking sites on their mobile phones.

Similarly, people use the Internet facility-centres and e-kiosks for e-governance and networking to mitigate marginalisation. For example, Akshaya e-centre located in Kerala is headed by A.M. Hameedkutty. “The organization interfaces with government agencies and focuses on the creation of ICT access points up to the village level through public participation” (cited in Vishnu A.:2007).

There are similar initiatives by individuals/organisations to use digital platforms for a participative-inclusive society—for example, the open learning platform developed by EkStep Foundation based in Karnataka. EkStep is a universal collaborative platform designed for accessible learning opportunities. The software/app facilitates networking of teachers/trainers, designers/developers, writers/artists, parents-learners, and many more who are contributing towards restructuring access to education. The participants create and publish interactive teaching content such as digital storybooks, games, etc. to be used for learning on the same platform. By publishing on an open license content platform, they share it with other users offline and online.

Activity-3

Visit any Internet-based platform of your choice, like the Facebook page, Twitter account or website of the Ministry of Minority Affairs and assess the ‘interface’ it provides for User-Generated-Content. Also, observe the source of the content thus created.

Activity-4

Identify the Internet-based media practices adopted or designed by the municipal body/gram panchayat of your locality to connect with the people in the area. Analyse the level of participation of the people in online communication on such platforms. Write a report on the same.

12.6 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit, we have discussed the process of marginalisation and characteristics of marginalised sections/individuals. We have discussed various forms of digital media and their potential as a medium for the marginalised sections by exploring the process of production, mediation, and participation. We have also examined the concepts such as - network embeddedness and heterogeneity, cyberoptimism and cyberpessimism, digital divide, and digital citizenship.

We have closely observed the concepts of representations and presentations. We have traced the unconventional forms of new media such as blogs, microblogs, animation, games, in order to assess their role in mainstreaming the marginalised. We have also discussed the language and meaning-making processes concerning the 'text' on the Internet. We have briefly looked at the acceptable practices from various parts of India, where we found that the Internet is being utilised as a medium for creating awareness, increasing participation and bringing the voices of the marginalised to the fore. Also, we have critically examined the Internet content to assess the representation of the marginalised.

To sum up, we can say that the Internet provides an 'interface' to the users to participate in the processes of inclusion. Since the representations on the Internet blur the lines of 'public' and 'private,' 'political' and 'personal,' the 'visibility' with increased network heterogeneity is essential. This is achievable by adding key technological elements such as improved streaming capabilities and user interface on mobile phones and other Internet platforms. Towards this, we need to facilitate the exchange of knowledge sets of the marginalised with the rest consistently and widely in order to mitigate the marginalised.

12.7 KEYWORDS

Animation: The process of drawing/creating moving images/sequences integrated into multimedia products.

Computer-mediated-communication (CMC) is the transmission of digitised information like email, blogs, etc. through telecommunications devices.

Community Media: The small/local media organisations based in rural/tribal/remote areas working with the objectives of development communication with the participation of local people.

Immersion: The feeling/experience of being a part of a constructed world/image with the use of new media technology as a part of Virtual Reality (VR), 3D video games/films.

Interface: The technical link (or software) between human and machine that enables users to access various functions of the computer.

Internet: The system of networks linked through computers and servers using telecommunications infrastructure.

Mediation: Intervention between sender and receiver of communication with the use of media technologies, usually through one-way information channels.

Meme: Form of content, created by using GIF/image/video or/and text with changed meaning and message and circulated online.

Representation: The media portrayals of particular groups/communities/experiences or issues generally with specific perspectives.

Self-representation: It is the image, one draws for oneself. Self presentation/representation online often leads to the cultural understanding of ‘one’s social surroundings’.

Simulacrum: The term was coined by the French scholar Jean Baudrillard about the state where it is not possible to differentiate between ‘the real’ and ‘the sign’. This is the condition of hyper reality with a simulation that seems ‘real’ even without existence in the real world.

Text: The media content that is ‘read’ and analysed for possible meanings.

Textuality is the characteristic of the text.

12.8 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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12.9 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

1. Marginalised are the individuals/groups/communities having no access to the resources and little control over their lives. Due to marginalisation, they are prevented/excluded from participation in economic-social-political decision-making and hence are not recognised as mainstream. They are the weaker sections, the victim of oppression, discrimination, vulnerability, and stigma. For example, homeless migrants, poor classes/castes, elderly, disabled people, women, children, etc.

2. Four measurement indexes are:
 - Human Development Index (HDI)
 - Gender Inequality Index (GII)
 - Multidimensional Poverty Index (MPI)
 - Global Competitiveness Index (GCI)
3. Marginalisation is a condition that changes when individuals/social groups achieve upward mobility with affirmative actions offered by the State and social institutions like education and media. In a life cycle, a child is marginalised with under-grown physical-mental strength; the marginality decreases when the child is grown into young/adult and participates in the economic-social-political sphere; again, the marginalisation increases with old age, due to lesser physical strength and control over life.

Check Your Progress: 2

- 1) Five elements of the Internet are Digital, interactivity, hypertextuality, virtuality, network, and simulation.
- 2) The element of diversity, Internet-based heterogeneity, is characterised either by technological devices like PC or mobile phone or in the form of content. It can be achieved through:
 - facilitating an easy interface for users.
 - We are making the Internet environment more receptive/ reciprocal by mechanisms of check on cyber-bullying; promotion of privacy and safety and thus, more participation.
 - Offline prompt actions linked with 'online' dialogue and discourse.
- 3) Net neutrality is the condition when all Internet traffic is treated equally by Internet service providers (ISP). It facilitates 'open web' and makes the Internet democratic, where everyone can express freely at all platforms. Thus, it adds more participation to widen the scope of digital citizenship that is based on the responsible use of technology.

UNIT 13 PARTICIPATORY ONLINE MEDIA

Structure

- 13.0 Introduction
- 13.1 Learning Outcomes
- 13.2 Approaches to Participation
 - 13.2.1 Sociological Approach
 - 13.2.2 Political Approach
- 13.3 Online Participation and Engagement
 - 13.3.1 Public Engagement in the New Media Environment
- 13.4 Youth Participatory Culture and Media Literacy
 - 13.4.1 New Media Literacies' (NML) Framework
- 13.5 Digital Media and Empowerment
 - 13.5.1 Civic Engagement and Youth Development
 - 13.5.2 Youth Empowerment and Participatory Politics
- 13.6 Role of Social Media in Online Participatory Communication
- 13.7 Experiments/Stories from India
- 13.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 13.9 References and Further Readings
- 13.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

13.0 INTRODUCTION

With the emergence of the new media, the participation of the citizens in the online platform has become prominent. It allows ordinary citizens to produce and disseminate content quickly to a broader audience. The World Wide Web (WWW) provides a place for information sharing to hungry citizens about the events happening in the world. It also offers a cheaper way for news organisations, interest groups or amateurs and enthusiasts to deliver to their prospective consumers. The new forms of participatory media have made 'two-way' conversation possible between the broadcaster/ publisher and the reader/viewer from that of a "lecturer" speaking to a passive "audience."

The participatory online culture has been one of the great promises of the new media. Early writers such as Rheingold (1994) envisaged the rise of a virtual public sphere, where Turkle (1995) saw the identity as being able to become much more fluid and changeable in the virtual world of cyberspace. The scope for new media to be more participatory arose from its apparent structural differences from the forms of mass communication that had been predominant media models in 20th-century societies. The concept of participatory media predates the rise of the Internet and networked ICTs. The sense that mainstream commercial media have failed to meet specific

objectives of the responsibility of the press and their inability to serve as a forum for the exchange of comment and criticism acted as a stimulus for the development of various forms of alternative media.

The rise of interactive media platforms have made untrained news professionals to be directly engaged with news events than ever before. The relatively low cost of new media creation technologies allowed any digital media literate citizen from any place of origin to create her/his own interactive news media. This kind of media is known as 'online participatory media'. It includes weblogs as well as Internet chat-rooms, wireless communication systems and mobile phones. In some Asian countries, young people use mobile phones as their primary vehicle for going online.

In this Unit, we shall discuss the online participatory media process and how the public gets engaged in the new media environment by using it as a potential tool in the democratic process.

13.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, you will be able to:

- describe the strength and limitations of online participatory media;
- explain participatory culture from the media literacy perspective;
- discuss how online participation can create more public engagement in the new media environment; and
- apply participatory methods through digital media to engage the youth in positive approaches.

13.2 APPROACHES TO PARTICIPATION

In recent years, 'participation' has become a common concept that appears in debates of social sciences and humanities. Although some level of citizen participation is generally understood as something positive and necessary in democratic societies, a discrepancy exists concerning the level of intensity of this participation. Different disciplines are debating on issues related to the extent of allowing citizen participation, their needs and preferences in the decision-making processes, and perhaps to identify the sectors of society which are still unrepresented. The literature on participation, including media and participation, has produced many different positions. There are mainly two main approaches:

- a. Sociological approach; and
- b. Political studies approach

13.2.1 Sociological Approach

The sociological approach defines participation as taking part in particular social processes, a definition which casts a vast net. In this approach, participation includes many types of human interaction in combination with interactions through texts and technologies. Power is not excluded from this

approach but remains one of the many secondary concepts to support it. Within media studies, the sociological approach can be found in how James Carey defined the ritual model of communication in his famous work on *Communication as Culture*, as the ‘representation of shared beliefs.’ For Carey, the ritual model of communication is explicitly linked to notions of ‘sharing, participation, association, fellowship and the possession of a common faith.’

13.2.2 Political Approach

Participatory Online Media It refers to equalisation of power inequalities in particular decision-making processes. Hence, participation is defined as the equalisation of power relations between privileged and non-privileged actors in formal or informal decision-making processes. The political approach also emphasises that participation is an object of struggle and that different ideological projects defend different participatory intensities.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the two approaches to participation?

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2. Define ‘participation’ in relation to the two approaches to participation.

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13.3 ONLINE PARTICIPATION AND ENGAGEMENT

Participatory culture is a term that is often used to talk about the apparent link between more accessible digital technologies, user-generated content, and some kind of shift in the power relations between media industries and their consumers. Another aspect of interactive participatory media is that it enables citizens in different countries to converse directly with one another without meeting each other, and without the mediating help of governments or

commercial media. By creating new opportunities for cross-border, citizen-to-citizen communications, weblogs and other forms of interactivity, participatory media is seen as a potential vehicle for crossborder non-governmental activism and citizen diplomacy.

In this new media environment, the media is being transformed by new technologies. This transformation will lead to loss of control by professionals over news reporting and dissemination of information about events around the world. The new media environment is in the process of creating a new model in which information flows both ways. An essential difference between traditional and interactive participatory media is regarding how the information flows. Interactive participatory media transforms a one-way conversation between media and “audience” into a conversation with an “information community.”

The term “community” here implies a web of multi-directional relationships and exchanges. Within traditional media, information flow is linear and unidirectional, where the information goes from sources to journalists, to editors, publication or broadcast and then to the audience. Online participatory media creates a non-linear and multi-directional information flow. Usually, from a blogger/journalist/web publisher or such a group of people, information and opinion go out to an interactive media site. The information is then consumed by members of the information community, many of whom react to the original “post” and add their contributions in the form of comments at the bottom of that “post.”

13.3.1 Public Engagement in the New Media Environment

Online participatory media enables more people in different countries to communicate with each other more easily and directly than ever before, without depending on governments or professional media to enable and mediate this conversation. Such cross-border conversations can be channelised to bridge significant cultural and digital divides. The newness of online participatory media is its ability to perform the following functions:

- a. link quickly, aggregate, and share information from a vast number of sources;
- b. derive meaning from this jumble of information through commentary;
- c. spontaneously generate online discussion communities around any given piece of information;
- d. enable discussion communities concerned with a particular issue to multiply and mutate in a rapid, self-replicating viral manner across the Internet.

The public engagement via online media is not motivated by a desire for profit but with a desire to improve the state of the world where the bloggers voice daily concerns on their weblogs. Yale Law School, Professor Yochai Benkler, argues that the shift is now taking place in the developed world from a physical, industrial-based economy to a “networked information economy”

making activities based on volunteerism, philanthropy and the desire for social justice more likely in cyberspace than in the physical economy.

The most exciting aspect of new media technologies is their ability to remove the costs associated with the processes of dissemination and facilitation of discussion. Even though the process of gathering quality, first-hand information will remain expensive, yet the nature of online participatory media offers the potential to use public financing and charitable donations much more effectively and efficiently in ways that are not possible with conventional forms of media.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. How does interactive participatory media help citizens in the new media environment?

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2. Mention any three essential functions of online participatory media.

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13.4 YOUTH PARTICIPATORY CULTURE AND MEDIA LITERACY

Jenkins et al. (2009) initiated the idea of participatory culture amongst young people in the context of online media from a media literacy perspective. Young people, as per Jenkins et al. (2009), play the role of consumers as well as producers in online media spaces. Ito et al. (2009) illustrate that youth participate in online media spaces for two primary purposes-friendship driven and interest-driven. In this context, Ito et al. (2009) identify three sub-genres of participation: hanging out (friendship-driven participation), messing around (acquiring a new skill online) and geeking out (intensive and focused participation after acquiring the skill online, hence, learning).

The notion of participatory culture, as per Jenkins et al. (2009) stems from three core gaps:

1. Participation Gap (unequal access to opportunities, experiences, skills and knowledge)
2. Transparency Problem (difficulty to recognise how media shapes their perception)
3. Ethics Challenge (ethics to communicate and participate responsibly in online media spaces)

The role of media education and literacy, therefore, becomes imperative to make online media a dynamic environment to be engaged with up to its full potential. Moreover, the participatory culture essentially shifts the focus on literacy from individual expression to community involvement, especially amongst young people.

They were borrowing the idea of “Affinity Spaces” (Gee, 2004), Jenkins et al. (2009) state that affinity spaces have become the base of participatory culture amongst young people which offers them opportunities to learn and also bridge differences of age, class, gender, race and educational level. Furthermore, participatory culture includes both popular cultures as well as informal learning for efficient participation in online media spaces.

There are four-forms of participatory culture:

1. *Affiliations* – forming formal and informal memberships in online communities centred around various forms of online media such as Friendster, Facebook, message boards, metagaming, game clans, etc.
2. *Expressions* – producing new forms such as digital sampling, skinning and modding, fan videomaking, fan fiction writing, zines, mash-ups, etc.
3. *Collaborative Problem-Solving* – working together in formal and informal teams to complete tasks and develop new knowledge through Wikipedia, alternative reality gaming, spoiling, etc.
4. *Circulations* – shaping the flow of media through podcasting and blogging.

13.4.1 New Media Literacies' (NML)

Framework Jenkins' et al. (2009) have identified 11 new media literacies that comprehensively cover social skills and cultural competencies amongst young people to fully participate in online media spaces. The new media literacies' framework is based on traditional literacy, research skills, technical skills and critical analysis skills taught in the classroom and are developed through collaborations and networking. Therefore, participatory culture as a concept combines traditional literacy skills (how to search information, evaluate the credibility of information, synthesise and make sense of information, make a decision and action) and new media literacy (social skills or methods of interaction with larger communities).

The core media literacy skills are as follows:

1. *Play: the capacity to experiment with one's surroundings as a form of problem-solving*

Through play, children and young people try on roles, experiment with culturally central processes, manipulate core resources, and explore their immediate environments. Children can play games and shift their emphasis from fun to engagement and learning, which is also enormously motivating for them. It allows educators to tap into play as a skill when they encourage free-form experimentation and open-ended speculation.

2. *Simulation: the ability to interpret and construct dynamic models of real-world processes*

New media provides powerful new ways of representing and manipulating information. New forms of simulation expand our cognitive capacity, allowing us to deal with larger bodies of information, to experiment with more complex configurations of data, to form hypotheses quickly and test them against different variables in real-time. Contemporary video games allow youth to play with sophisticated simulations and, in the process, to develop an intuitive understanding of how we might use simulations to test our assumptions about the way the world works.

3. *Performance: the ability to adopt alternative identities for improvisation and discovery*

The game play also is one of a range of contemporary forms of youth popular culture that encourages young people to assume fictitious identities and through this process, develop a richer understanding of themselves and their social roles. Educators have used dramatisations to teach children to reflect more deeply on their experiences of stories. One of the most prominent examples is Model United Nations (MUN) which helps young people to develop new knowledge and strategies by donning alternative identities.

4. *Appropriation: the ability to meaningfully sample and remix media content*

Appropriation is understood as a process by which students learn by taking culture apart and putting it back together. It may be understood as a process that involves both analysis and commentary. Sampling intelligently from the existing cultural reservoir requires a close analysis of the existing structures and uses of this material; remixing requires an appreciation of emerging structures and underlying potential meanings. Such appropriation is visible in drama, theatre, Participatory Online Media art and music and can also be acknowledged in terms of gaining insight on educational materials.

5. *Multi-tasking: the ability to scan one's environment and shift focus onto salient details on an ad hoc basis*

Focusing attention is essential in order to learn cohesively, but difficult for learners nowadays mainly due to the emergence of digital media. However, instead of focusing on narrowing attention, young people often respond to a rich media environment by multi-tasking. Multitasking involves a method of monitoring and responding to the sea of information around us. Students need help distinguishing between being off task and handling multiple tasks simultaneously. Currently, young people are playing with these skills as they engage with games or social activities that reward the ability to maintain a mental picture of complex sets of relationships and to adjust quickly to shifts in perceptual cues.

6. *Distributed Cognition: The ability to interact meaningfully with tools that expand our mental capacities.*

Applications of the distributed cognition perspective to education suggests that students must learn the different tools and information technologies, and know in which functions of tools and technologies to excel at and in what contexts they can be trusted. Students need to acquire patterns of thought that regularly cycle through available sources of information as they make sense of developments in the world around them. One of the recent examples is Augmented Reality (AR) which is a potential tool for distributed intelligence to apply in the learning process.

7. *Collective Intelligence: the ability to pool knowledge and compare notes with others towards a common goal*

Currently, children and adults are acquiring the skills to operate within knowledge communities by interacting with popular culture. We often learn through play that we later apply to more serious tasks. For example, young Pokemon fans, of whom each one knows some crucial detail about the various species, constitute a collective intelligence whose knowledge is extended each time two youth on the playground, share something about the franchise. Educators can deploy aspects of collective intelligence when students pool observations and work through interpretations with others studying the same problem from scattered locations. Such knowledge communities can confront problems of greater scale, and complexity than any individual student might be able to handle.

8. *Judgment: the ability to evaluate the reliability and credibility of different information sources*

The new mediated landscape of mainstream news sources, collaborative blog projects, unsourced news sites, and increasingly sophisticated marketing techniques aimed at ever-younger consumers demand that students be taught how to distinguish fact from fiction, the argument from documentation, real from fake, and marketing from enlightenment. Even when media content has been determined credible, it is vital for the student also to identify and analyse the perspective of the producer: who is presenting what to whom, and why. Media literacy education, therefore, relies heavily on the concept of judgment to distinguish information from misinformation and disinformation.

9. *Transmedia Navigation: the ability to deal with the flow of stories and information across multiple modalities*

Transmedia stories at the most basic level are stories told across multiple media. Modern literacy requires the ability to express ideas across a broad range of different systems of representation and signification including words (spoken or written), images (still or moving), music, 3D models, etc. Students must learn to sort through a range of different possible modes of expression, determine which is most effective in reaching their audience and communicating their message, and to grasp which techniques work best in conveying information through this channel.

10. *Networking: the ability to search for, synthesise, and disseminate information*

In a world in which knowledge production is collective and communication occurs across an array of different media, the capacity to network emerges as a core social skill and cultural competency. Students today tap into popular search systems such as Google.com, Amazon, etc., readily available on Web 2.0 to collect and annotate data for themselves as well as for other users. Therefore, networking is only partially about identifying potential resources; it also involves a process of synthesis, during which multiple resources are combined to produce new knowledge. Educators take advantage of social networking when they link learners with others who might share their interests or when they encourage students to publish works produced to a broader public.

11. *Negotiation: the ability to travel across diverse communities, discerning and respecting multiple perspectives, and grasping and following alternative sets of norms*

The fluid communication within the new media environment brings together groups who otherwise might have lived segregated lives. Culture flows smoothly from one community to another. People online encounter conflicting values and assumptions, come to grips with competing claims about the meaning of shared artefacts and experiences. Therefore, it becomes increasingly critical to help students acquire skills in understanding multiple perspectives, respecting and even embracing the diversity of views, understanding a variety of social norms, and negotiating between conflicting opinions. Educators can foster negotiation skills when they bring together groups from diverse backgrounds and provide them with resources and processes that ensure careful listening and more in-depth communication. Therefore, the core media literacy skills as highlighted by Jenkins et al. Participatory Online Media (2009) combine social skills and cultural competencies in and out of school for young people to adapt and learn virtually about the dynamic environment through the tools available at hand. Apart from school, parents become another agency who can help shape the relationship of young people with online tools for enhancing their mental capacities in order to be media and information literate right from communication to effective participation in the online media spaces.

13.5 DIGITAL MEDIA AND EMPOWERMENT

In the global context of digital media penetration and users' profiles indicate that this medium is more popular among the youth, more precisely in the age group of 13 to 35 from diverse backgrounds. This youth-oriented media adoption is being reflected in the Indian media scenario as well.

The digital media provides platforms for higher levels of interactivity, and eventually, it facilitates active participation from Internet users. Young users of online media are utilising their digital skills for various communication and interaction purposes, which mostly, centres around their personal settings and academic/professional levels. However, the same digital medium could be utilised for multiple public causes, and one such opportunity is that of young people's involvement in civic engagement. Since, the concept of civic engagement is meant for a public audience, adequate conceptual as well as skill-oriented support is one of the prerequisites for youth engagement.

For a better understanding of the term civic engagement, we would contextualise the term civic engagement to any of the activities pertinent to political engagements (election process, which includes voting as well as creating awareness associated with it), civic engagement refers to the activities related to volunteering for public causes, community works, social welfare etc. Beyond the political and civic engagements, any individual who closely observes and follows the national, regional and international developments in order to make them knowledgeable about these affairs. This is called psychological engagement, where individuals may have strong understanding and opinions about various issues. However, they may or may not participate publicly on issues in which they have a strong familiarity with it.

In general, the digital and online media facilitates better communication and interactivity. However more precisely the social media and mobile technologies enable a closer association with the individuals and their engagement in political, civic and psychological engagements.

13.5.1 Civic Engagement and Youth Development

There is a direct relationship between the personality of an individual and his/her engagement with public affairs which includes political process, social movements, academic activities and so on. Each person especially young people's social determinants play an essential role in quality and quantity of their civic engagements.

Secondly, social ties developed over the digital platform with other interested people plays an important factor that influences their engagement in online platforms. Along with these factors, online social media networks facilitate better participation of young people in public affairs. The unique features of online media - multimedia contents that include text with the audio-video elements - helps these young users to engage with the variety of formats of user-generated contents. The interactive characteristics of online engagements motivate the interested youths to make more association and

collaborations for deeper engagement with the contents shared through digital platforms.

13.5.2 Youth Empowerment and Participatory Politics

Young people who mainly hail from marginalised communities tend to utilise the online platform for their improvements, voice the concerns of their respective community issues and explore diverse sets of knowledge. These explorations for their individual as well as community welfare over a period of time leads to more attachment with the public causes and strengthens the interest of young people towards the upliftments of disadvantaged sections of the society.

The digital platform provides horizontal level of communication among its members and all these interactions are in the non-hierarchical category. It helps the young people to access, discuss, share and mobilise resources and people for a change in their community or they are motivated to expect an action and reaction within the broader social context. These motivated engagements with the digital media platform tends to provide a positive change within individuals as well as results better expected outcomes for their community as a whole.

Based on a study on online racial discrimination in academic motivation published in 2015 by Tynes BM et al. it was discovered that when young people seek political information or express political voice online, they may expose themselves to stereotypes and hate speech, which can have a negative impact on well-being particularly for the minority youth. However, overall studies of media used by politically active youth reveal that many are aware of the potential consequences of online political expression and navigate those risks in varied ways.

The Occupy movement stopping the Stop Online Piracy Act (SOPA) and the power of six million users of change.org are only two among many examples of how new media has impacted politics in the USA, especially as politics that is practised among young people. The use of social media by the Obama campaign in 2008 helped to produce record turnout, especially among young Blacks and Latinos. In the 2012 elections, all those involved in campaigns were relying more heavily on social media than ever before. The intersection of youth, new media, and politics is not exclusively a story from the United States. The recent movements from Tunisia to Egypt to Russia indicate that the significance of new media's impact on political expression is international in its scope.

To consider the impact of new media on the political and civic behaviour of young people, The MacArthur Research Network on Youth and Participatory Politics (YPP) developed and fielded one of the first large-scale, nationally representative studies of new media and politics among young people. The two principal researchers for the survey component of the YPP, Cathy J. Cohen of the University of Chicago and Joseph Kahne of Mills College, oversaw a research team that surveyed nearly 3,000 respondents between Participatory Online Media the ages of 15 and 25 years of age. Unlike any

prior study of youth and new media, this study included large numbers of Black, Latino, and Asian American respondents, which allowed for unique and powerful statistical comparisons across race with a focus on young people.

The YPP study findings suggest that fundamental changes in political expectations and practices may be occurring— especially among the youth. The analysis of the data collected reveals that youth are taking advantage of an expanded set of participatory practices in the political realm in ways that amplify their voice and sometimes their influence, thus increasing the ways in which young people participate in political life. The YPP researchers label this expanded set of opportunities and actions as participatory politics.

While the topic of new media and youth politics has garnered lots of attention from pundits, politicians, and journalists, these reports often focus on anecdotal or single-case examples of a protest mobilisation where new media played an important role. To date, there has been limited opportunity and data available to explore the relationship between new media and the political action of young people in a more comprehensive manner. This new survey data provides a strong basis for five major findings, summarised as follows:

Large proportions of young people across racial and ethnic groups have access to the Internet and use online social media regularly to stay connected with their family and friends and pursue interests and hobbies.

1. Participatory politics is an essential dimension of politics.
2. Participatory politics is an addition to an individual's engagement rather than an alternative to other political activities.
3. Participatory politics are equitably distributed across different racial and ethnic groups.
4. Youth get news through participatory channels but believe they would benefit from learning how to judge the credibility of what they find online.

Participatory politics is a significant dimension of the political life of young people giving them greater control, voice, and potential influence over the issues that matter most in their lives. New media has the potential to facilitate equitable distribution of political participation among young people from different racial and ethnic groups. Participatory politics is generally equitably distributed across different racial and ethnic groups. Youth now consume a great deal of news through participatory channels.

Check Your Progress: 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Point out two contemporary examples of new media's impact on political expression by the youth.

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2. Why is participation in civic life considered very important for the youth?

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13.6 ROLE OF SOCIAL MEDIA IN ONLINE PARTICIPATORY COMMUNICATION

Social media applications, including social networking sites, blogs, podcasts and content shares, have been used to facilitate a participatory cultural experience by several institutions. Participatory culture is a term that is often used for designating the involvement of users, audiences, consumers and fans in the creation of culture and content. Many scholars actively believe that culture and society have become more democratic with the users and the audiences creating and producing their own content rather than being mere passive receivers. Examples are the collaborative editing of an article on Wikipedia, the uploading of images onto Facebook, the uploading of videos onto YouTube and the creation of short messages on Twitter. It enables more and more people to become media producers and distributors as well as consumers.

Traditional media institutions have failed in providing online spaces to foster public speech and interactions among citizens. Citizens, in their daily use of social media, encounter different identities and political positions, which challenge their own perceptions and attitudes towards 'the political'. Secondly, it will present how social media become spaces where debate spreads more quickly than in online spaces. By doing so, social networks are contributing to challenging one of the former hegemonies of traditional media institutions viz. the conception of news media as the main actors that enhance debate among citizens, selecting the issues of the day and facilitating current affairs content through which citizens can comment and debate. However, euphoria about the potential for social networks to reshape the media sphere should be limited.

According to Jenkins, an American media scholar, the main characteristic of "social media"/"web 2.0" is that they are spreadable media (Jenkins, Li, Krauskopf and Green 2009): "Consumers play an active role in 'spreading'

content [. . .] Consumers in this model are [. . .] grassroots advocates for materials which are personally and socially meaningful to them" (Jenkins et al. 2009). Spreadable media are based on the logic "if it doesn't spread, it's dead" (Jenkins, Ford and Green 2013) and involve audiences that "actively" shape "media flows" so that culture becomes "far more participatory."

According to Jenkins, social media is also an expression of participatory culture. Jenkins defines participatory culture as culture "in which fans and other consumers are invited to actively participate in the creation and circulation of new content" (Jenkins 2008). It also involves "participants who interact with each other" (Jenkins 2008). Participation involves, for Jenkins, "new forms of participation and collaboration" (Jenkins 2008). Jenkins points out, based on Pierre Levy (1997), that those who engage in "participatory culture" pool resources and combine skills so that collective intelligence emerges as "an alternative source of media power" (Jenkins Participatory Online Media 2008).

The online space is both a space of participation on the one hand and also a space for commodification. Convergence is both a top-down corporate driven process and a bottom-up consumer-driven process. There is no doubt that Web 2.0 users are creative when they generate and diffuse user generated content. However, the question is also how many Web 2.0 users are active and what degree of activity and creativity do their practices have. Creativity is a force that enables Internet prosumer commodification, the commodification and exploitation of the users' activities and the data they generate. Creativity is not outside or alongside exploitation on web 2.0; it is at its very foundation.

Jenkins (2008) argues that YouTube is a site "for the production and distribution of grassroots media" and that on YouTube "participation occurs at three distinct levels [. . .] – those of production, selection, and distribution" (Jenkins 2008). Because Google owns YouTube hence, that the revenues that are accumulated with online advertising on YouTube do not belong to the immediate content producers, but the shareholders of Google. Jenkins here neglects ownership as a central aspect of participation. The most popular YouTube videos stem from global multimedia corporations like Universal, Sony and Walt Disney. Google and Facebook are based on targeted advertising models and a commercial culture, which results in enormous profits for these companies.

In the corporate social media sphere, attention is unequally distributed: big companies, celebrities and well-known political actors enjoy attention advantages and the most active prosumers come from the young, educated middle class. Jenkins (2008) celebrates blogs as a "means for their participants to express their distrust of the news media and their discontent with politics as usual," "potentially increasing cultural diversity and lowering barriers in cultural participation," "expanding the range of perspectives," as "grassroots intermediaries" that ensure "that everyone has a chance to be heard" (Jenkins 2006). He forgets the lack of visibility in the public sphere of most political blogs. Political blogs have hardly been able to reach the large

numbers of readers of the websites of big corporates like CNN and The New York Times.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What is participatory culture?

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2. In what ways are social media networks challenging the traditional form of media?

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The ‘networked population’ of the world has grown exponentially from a million in the 1990s to a billion in the first decade of the 21st century. This is a remarkable increase in the pace of adoption of new technology by society at large. From politics to business, common man to celebrities, activists to the government – all of them look at social media as essential.

Recent technological innovations have put the tools of production of media content in the hands of the common man. It allows anybody with access to the net to reach across to millions. It gives voice to erstwhile voiceless. So, the mainstream media has tried to overcome the adversity by proactively co-opting the new content to face the threat. Many news channels are vying with each other to showcase videos from video sharing sites. Therefore, the media landscape is changing rapidly.

Journalists in mainstream media have found themselves in a challenging situation. They have realised the need to change and that they are forced to change. Journalists do not control the message anymore. Earlier they would decide on what is newsworthy and vital. The entire world would watch, listen to them in awe, swallowing unquestionably every single word they would utter.

13.7 EXPERIMENTS/STORIES FROM INDIA

When CNN introduced the 24x7 news TV in 1981, the power of 'live' reporting from the battlefield rendered audiences speechless, mesmerised, glued in front of their TV screens. Today web video is everywhere. Breaking news is catapulted into cyberspace through Twitter or Facebook by the random witness-turned-reporter who uses his/her smartphone and captures the 'exclusive' story.

People love being part of the innovation game. Young audiences have become more important and influential than ever before. It is as if they are born with an innate ability for text messaging, 'iPodding', gaming and multi-tasking on multiple platforms. They are tech-savvy, and they are active players, influencers, and decision-makers. The option to share content freely on sites like YouTube and peer-to-peer networks like BitTorrent means that consumers can bypass official media distribution channels, eroding media companies' traditional revenue streams of ad impressions and purchasing or subscription fee.

It is essential to begin by understanding various social media sites and the ways they can enhance the work journalists do. A regular perusal of sites like 10000words.net and savethemedia.com is a great way to do this. However, it is also essential that we move beyond acquainting ourselves with this world and figure out how to "use" it for journalism, which requires understanding its nature and impact on participants and public life? What needs our attention is how we are going to play roles that bring journalistic values into this vast social media territory.

According to the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI) report, the number of social media users in urban India had reached 400 million by December 2019. Nearly three out of four of all active internet users in urban India use social media.

Hence, in order to capitalise on the use of mobile phone and Internet for Participatory Online Media mobilising communities in a participatory manner, there are organisations in India who are working with the communities, youth and children.

- CGNet Swara is a platform to discuss issues related to the Central Gondwana region in India. (<http://cgnetswara.org/>)
- Gaon connection is Indian rural media platform where the attempt is to sustain the rural journalism through online spaces (<https://www.gaonconnection.com/>).
- Radio Brahmaputra is the only grassroots community radio of the Northeastern region located in Dibrugarh, Assam.
- Project CHIME (Children in Media Experiments) is the first participatory video initiative from Northeast India from Shillong, Meghalaya. (<https://chimenortheast.wordpress.com/>)

13.8 LET US SUM UP

We have learnt in this Unit that, the scope for new media to be more participatory arose from its apparent structural differences earlier from the forms of mass communication that had been predominant media models in 20th-century societies. The rise of interactive media platforms has made it possible for untrained news professionals to be directly engaged with news events than ever before.

We also discussed two approaches of participation—sociological and political. The sociological approach defines participation as taking part in particular social processes. The political approach to participation refers to equalisation of power inequalities in particular decision-making processes.

Besides that this Unit discussed that young people who are most involved in interest-driven activities are also much more engaged in political activity. There are numerous reasons why interest-driven activities facilitate political engagement. The lack of gatekeepers and vetting of the information that circulates via the web has led to concerns that many youths may be getting their information exclusively or primarily through participatory channels. For the vast majority of youth, participatory channels supplement their news diet.

We also learnt that, traditional media institutions are failing in providing online spaces to foster public speech and interactions among citizens. Citizens, in their daily use of social media, encounter different identities and political positions, which challenge their perceptions and attitudes towards 'the political'. The online space is both a space of participation on the one hand and also a space for commodification. Convergence is both a topdown corporate-driven process and a bottom-up consumer-driven process. This Unit discussed about the organisations in India who are working with the communities, youth and children.

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13.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

1. Sociological approach and Political approach
2. According to the sociological approach, participation includes many types of human interaction in combination with interactions with texts and technologies. Power is not excluded from this approach but remains one of the many secondary concepts to support it. On Participatory Online Media the other hand, for the political approach, participation is defined as the equalisation of power relations between privileged and nonprivileged actors in formal or informal decision-making processes. The political approach also allows for emphasising that participation is an object of struggle and that different ideological projects defend different participatory intensities.

Check Your Progress: 2

1. Participatory culture is a term that is often used to talk about the apparent link between more accessible digital technologies, user generated

content, and some shift in the power relations between media industries and their consumers. Interactive, participatory media transform a one-way conversation between media and “audience” into a conversation with an “information community.” The term “community” here implies a web of multi-directional relationships and exchanges. Within traditional media, information flow is linear and unidirectional, where the information goes from sources to journalists, to editors, publication or broadcast and then to the audience. Online participatory media creates a non-linear and multi-directional information flow.

2. The three essential functions of online participatory media are: a) quickly link, aggregate, and share information from a vast number of sources; b) derive meaning from this jumble of information through commentary; c). spontaneously generate online discussion communities around any given piece of information.

Check Your Progress: 3

1. The Occupy movement stopping the Stop Online Piracy Act (SOPA); b) Power of six million users of change.org
2. Participatory politics are a significant dimension of the political life of young people giving them greater control, voice, i.e. to potentially influence the issues that matter most in their lives. New media has the potential to facilitate equitable distribution of political participation among young people from different racial and ethnic groups.

Check Your Progress: 4

1. Participatory culture is a term that is often used for designating the involvement of users, audiences, consumers and fans in the creation of culture and content. Many scholars actively believe that culture and society become more democratic with the users and the audiences creating and producing their own content rather than being mere passive receivers. Examples are the collaborative editing of an article on Wikipedia, the uploading of images to Facebook, the uploading of videos to YouTube and the creation of short messages on Twitter. It enables more and more people to become media producers and distributors as well as consumers.
2. Traditional media institutions have failed to provide online spaces to foster public speech and interactions among citizens. Citizens, in their daily use of social media, encounter different identities and political positions, which challenge their own perceptions and attitudes towards ‘the political’. Secondly, social media debate spreads more easily. Social networks are contributing to challenging one of the former hegemonies of traditional media institutions viz. the conception of news media as the main actor that enhance debate among citizens, selecting the issues of the day and facilitating current affairs content through which citizens can comment and debate.

UNIT 14 ONLINE ACTIVISM

Structure

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- 14.1 Learning Outcomes
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 - 14.2.1 Definition
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- 14.3 Activism and Social Movements
 - 14.3.1 Impact of Internet Activism
- 14.4 Technology and Activism/Social Movements
 - 14.4.1 Offline and Online Activism
- 14.5 Characteristics of Online Activism
 - 14.5.1 Types of Online Activism
 - 14.5.2 Tools of Online Activism
- 14.6 Online Activism and Social Change
 - 14.6.1 Global Trends
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- 14.8 Keywords
- 14.9 References and Further Readings
- 14.10 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

14.0 INTRODUCTION

There are billions of Internet users, and for any given topics/issues we may find millions of users who are interested in it. A good number of interested users might want to go beyond accessing the information on their interested topics/issues, mainly they are interested in associating themselves with a cause. Some of them may be motivated enough to go for offline demonstrations to impress upon the concerned authorities or groups or individuals to change the situation or implementation of the new policy. Many of the like-minded Internet users simply give their support by changing their 'status' in social media accounts in solidarity with the groups in which they are associated. These online/offline actions for a cause/change using any tools of digital platforms are the focus of this Unit - Online Activism.

At the very outset, let us understand this Unit with the definition of online activism and in particular the different associated terms - like cyberactivism, Internet activism or broadly speaking media activism. The Unit would further discuss the historiography and the development of online activism. It would introduce you to different cases from across the world, which became the

guiding force for online activism. In doing so, the reference to the Indian perspective would also be discussed. A distinction needs to be made between offline and online activism. Later on, we would like to conclude by discussing how this activism is taking shape in the present century with the development of information technology and changing socio-politico economic scenario. Through the Unit, you would get a broader outlook on the concept of online activism and its different aspects.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After reading this Unit, the you will be able to:

- understand the concept of online activism;
- explore the historiography of activism worked at different times and particularly after the advent of the Internet and new media;
- identify the characteristics, tools, and significance of online activism;
- distinguish between offline and online activism and different types of online activism; and
- describe some of the cases related to online activism in the global as well as Indian context.

14.2 UNDERSTANDING ONLINE ACTIVISM

Let us first discuss the definition of online activism, and then we would understand the views given by different scholars on this phenomenon.

14.2.1 Definition

The term online activism is the offshoot of media activism which has always been part of mainstream media and citizen journalism. Digital activism, also known as cyberactivism, is a form of activism that uses the Internet and digital media as crucial platforms for mass mobilisation and political action.

Apart from the news and stories put forth for public discussion and decision making, there are times when the media plays an active role in deliberately bringing some stories which are socially relevant which is defined as media activism. The public comes out and supports that issue, but otherwise, it usually is not given adequate importance by the other social institutions. Thus, media apart from working as a watchdog also turns into the role of an activist raising voice for specific issues.

Another term, as mentioned earlier, citizen journalism is the concept where the ordinary public acts as the eyes and the ears of the media organisations. Moreover, this common public, the citizens, address specific issues of their locality and make media contents which they may send to the media organisations for telecast or be uploaded onto new media platforms. Based on the news values of relevance, timeliness, and other factors, media organisations may choose to show that content to the public. These citizen journalists might also independently start their online channels on social media platforms.

Earlier in the case of print media, there were sections, which still exist, as 'letters to the editor' where the readers would bring to the notice of the newspaper, specific issues of their locality which were deemed as an essential issue.

Now with the advent of new media and the Internet, the citizens/users have Online Activism got the opportunity to speak on the issues relevant to them. Furthermore, everyone is connected through the networked world. This not only gives amplification to the voice but also makes it prominent to be heard by the policymakers, government, judiciary, other law enforcement agencies, and the world watchdogs and official bodies.

In this networked world, especially, with the advent of Web 2.0 and the emergence of different social networking sites, the impact of online activism has gained prominence. Nevertheless, online activism has its own pros and cons, which we will discuss later. However, mostly the voices are put on the platforms which are further amplified to be heard by the world connected by the network.

14.2.2 Perspectives on Online Activism

Guobin Yang (2009) explains that "In online activism, most common forms include online

petitions, the hosting of campaign websites, and large-scale verbal protests." He further elaborates that "The most radical form is the hacking of websites. These forms of contention may be found in blogs, Internet bulletin boards, online communities, and podcasts and YouTube type websites."

Graham Meikle (2014) has defined Internet Activism as "Political uses of networked computers that attempt to effect social or cultural change in the offline world: a politics which can use the graphical and multimedia capabilities of the web as well as text-based applications such as email."

Further, Allen Rusbridger, the former editor of The Guardian has defined the characteristics of new media by stating that this technology has brought a new model of transmission of information, messages, and news compared to the traditional gate keeping model/top-to-bottom approach of news flow.

Rusbridger explains that with this new technology, now the bottom-to-top approach would come where news and its content would be directed by the audience what they want to see and the issues they want to address. He gave the example of The Guardian, where first the news provider floats an issue for the netizens to react and give their responses. Accordingly, then the newspaper takes up that issue for transmission. So, there comes an almost opposite model from top-to-bottom to a bottom-up approach.

Manuel Castells (2015) has defined networked communication as mass self communication. It is mass communication because it processes messages from many-to-many, with the potential of reaching a multiplicity of receivers, and of connecting to endless networks that transmit digitised information around the neighbourhood or around the world. It is self communication

because the production of the message is autonomously decided by the sender, the designation of the receiver is self-directed, and the retrieval of messages from the networks of communication is self-selected. Mass self-communication is based on horizontal networks of interactive communication that, by and large, are difficult to control by governments or corporations.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Explain the forms of Online Activism?

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2. What is the bottom-up approach in news transmission?

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14.3 ACTIVISM AND SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

As you are aware that activism as a concept is not a new phenomenon. It had existed ever since the world started when somebody stood up to encounter the ruling and authoritative force trying to set rules or making decisions that do not go well with the common people. In the modern sense, we can find a lot many examples where people stood for what they believed and challenged those in power to bring about change. We can see the civil rights movement in the USA, the French revolution, the Russian revolution, the Hippie movement throughout the world, the feminist movement, and many others.

In the context of India, in modern history, we can find the Santhal rebellion, the first struggle for India's independence, and Mahatma Gandhi's nonviolence movement. Ambedkar's movement leading the Dalits was a social-political movement, and the JP Movement was a youth movement for bringing societal and political change. The Chipko movement was started by a group of women and Chandi Prasad Bhatt to protect trees and the environment. After the 1960s (post-industrial economy), the new social movements came into existence. These mostly catered to issues not related to economic well-being but human rights.

There are instances of local people and tribes who also stood against the corporate and government projects. One can find a lot many socio-economic politico and environmental issues where people protested by coming on the streets and showed solidarity for the movement by different measures either by funding or physical support.

14.3.1 Impact of Internet Activism

With the advent of new media and particularly social media and mobile revolution in India, the protests and their expression have changed. People shifted from grass-roots activism to virtual activism, and in most cases, it was the combination of two. Whether such activism has helped or not, however, this needs to be understood and discussed.

Also in the clutter of social media content with no authority or gatekeeper, it is not clear who is ultimately going to set the tone to the communication around any given area/topic; whether the issues discussed are the real issues; whether any positive change has resulted or not. These perspectives need to be pointed out. In this context, the Internet has become an essential tool for raising the voice, while at the same time, it causes discord, chaos, and Online Activism hostility among the public.

Manuel Castells (2015) has described the whole phenomenon as individuals expressing their views which are against the government and corporations leading to mass communication in the face of fear and despair leading towards hope. This networked society is governed by the programmers and switchers.

Activity – 1

Take up one issue which was highly mobilised through online platforms and find more details through a simple online search. Through simple analysis of search results, try to find answers for the following questions:

- (i) What is the issue?
- (ii) When and where it happened?
- (iii) Role of Online Media in propagation, finding solutions or distorting the issue.

14.4 TECHNOLOGY AND ACTIVISM/SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

Increasing accessibility and the ability to communicate with thousands of citizens instantaneously has made the Internet, a tool of choice for individuals or organisations looking to spread a social message far and wide. Independent activists, the world over, are using the Internet and digital tools to build their community, connect with other like-minded people outside their physical surroundings as well as the lobby, raise funds, and organise events.

Simply put, digital activism is where digital tools (the Internet, mobile phones, social media, etc.) are used towards bringing about social and/or

political change. Digitalisation started to change with the advent of web 2.0 and the dot com boom. The introduction and rapid growth of social media platforms such as Facebook and Twitter post-2004 have helped digital activism to the point where entire campaigns can now be run online with a broad reach. Many scholars argue that digital tools alone do not suffice when it comes to galvanising people towards creating change. According to the online activism think tank Meta-Activism Project, digital activism should serve six key functions: **shaping public opinion; planning an action; protecting activists; sharing a call to action; taking action digitally, and transfer of resources**. Let us explore these six key functions of online activism in brief details.

1. **Shaping Public Opinion:** Usually, the mainstream media sets the agenda for society. By this method, they tend to deliberately ignore various issues due to their professional and business-centric nature of their operations. In this context, people who are aggrieved and oppressed mobilise constant and continuous discussion over the various online platforms, mainly through social media. According to the Meta-Activism project, “Social media is different because the means of information transmission also creates collective identity and collective grievance creates optimism.”
2. **Planning an Action:** Changing public opinion and creating new perspectives on any given issues or circumstances is quite possible through social media, the reason is that in the social media platform every individual is in touch with almost everyone participating in it. Hence many-to-many communication facilitates a collective identity, and that facilitates a changing public perception and opinion. Once public opinion gains momentum, it needs to be translated into action in the ground - in the offline environment. An effective planning process is required to carry out an action to take it forward to the collective identity and public opinion. For effective planning of a social movement, a small group of strategists is sufficient, unlike the mass members required for public opinion formation.
3. **Protecting Activists:** Mobilising public opinion against powerful groups is not an easy way, it brings its own consequences. Incidentally, the Internet provides ample scope for many activists to work/operate anonymously - pseudonyms or anonymous names are popular deceptive methods adopted by many activists in order to escape the wrath of powerful groups. However, the deceptive strategies, are hardly escape the digital footprints.
4. **Sharing a Call to Action:** Updating “status” or changing “profile” pictures or similar personal updates in social media, conveys a strong message to intended audiences - it is a low-cost broadcast to mass audiences. Similar to chain reactions, individuals are provoked to continue the stated actions which further spread the messages to various audiences.

5. **Taking actions Digitally:** Culmination of the first stages of digital activism lands in taking some concrete steps to make the “voices” are heard. As mentioned earlier about various forms of activism, according to Guobin Yang, signing e-petitions, writing emails, hosting online banners, and similar digital-only tactics to convey the message to the intended audience - here the policymakers or government officials or corporate groups or powerful elites.
6. **Transfer of Resources:** In order to sustain the first five stages of digital activism, constant financial support is required. Since some of the social movements engage in innovative ways of crowd funding to seek financial support from like-minded individuals.

These six stages of digital activism is a generalised pattern after observing many social movements that are carried out with the significant support of social media. You will find differences and similarities between these six stages if you closely scrutinise any specific digital activism based social movements.

Owing to the technological development and availability of smartphones and in-built applications, millions of users can be connected in one platform. Also, there is a limited level of screening/censorship/gatekeeping on this medium until somebody reports to the administration of the service provider of the application. This helps to repress the user's voices uncensored/unedited for the friends and public to respond. This medium also becomes the extension of the public sphere where people can participate in the rational debates expressing their views on topics of public interest. However, sometimes people burst into an expression of emotion and passion on this platform Online Activism which leads to contention and hate views being propagated.

There is a self/social gratification among the audience/users. The users have become now the creators of the content. This content generated by the user generally gratifies their need which not necessarily be based on any rationale. This process comes under the framework of uses and gratification theory.

14.4.1 Offline and Online Activism

Before proceeding further, we need to distinguish between the two contrasting concepts - online and offline based activism - based on the medium used for bringing about social change. The distinction is given below in the form of a table:

S. No.	Distinction Point	Online Activism	Offline Activism
1	Definition	Person(s)/People taking stand in the public by showing support/outrage/protest/ resistance for / against any issue.	Person(s)/People taking a stand on online medium by showing solidarity/support/outrage/protest/ resistance for/against any issue.

2	The medium of support/resistance	The support/resistance happens in the real world at the site of support/protest.	It happens in the virtual space (online portals/websites/social media platforms) on occasions resulting in grass root changes.
3	Form of Activism	Real grass-roots activism.	Mostly Passive Activism/Slacktivism.
4	Reward/Punishment	It is happening in the real world, so reward and punishment would be there.	Here the form of activism is not structured. Many times unidentified
5	Change	Happens at the grass-root level, hence chances of change are more.	May not bring about change if the support of virtual space does not become a grass-roots force.
6	Visibility of People Coming Together	Congregation of people is visible.	Not visible. Only numbers are visible or by signing campaigns which are only a number on the screen.
7	Congregation	People available at one place or plan to come together simultaneously at different places.	People divided by time and space joined by an online platform.
8	Resolution	Can come with a resolution for change.	Since people are located away from each other, no consensus can be brought about. No resolution can be made. Only dialogue happens. No change.
9	Effects Positive	Effects mostly as people come together to get a solution for some issues.	Negative effects. Like fake news leading social discord, chaos, and mistrust.
10	Example	Kundankulam Protest, Narmada Bachao Andolan, Niyamgiri Protest.	MeToo Campaign, Arab Spring

14.5 CHARACTERISTICS OF ONLINE ACTIVISM

The characteristics of online activism lie in its potential for bringing people together who are separated by time and space to discuss issues of sociopolitical relevance. Let us discuss all these aspects one by one.

- i. Formation of public sphere (concept given by Jürgen Habermas): The new media provides a platform where people separated by time and space get a chance to interact on issues of social relevance to form a consensus through rational and critical debates.
- ii. A large number of people available on one platform. So platform of solidarity and dissent.
- iii. Can guide public opinion formation. Influential people can air their thoughts, opinions, reactions which may be followed by the followers.
- iv. Act as a pressure group on government, policymakers, and lawabiding agencies.
- v. As a social watchdog, people can go 'live' on cases of corruption and ill-treatment. That voice can be amplified by the people.

14.5.1 Types of Online Activism

- i. **Active Online Activism/Ground Change Activism** This form of online activism brings about change at the grass-root level. People's voices take prominence, and public opinion leads to social change.

- ii. **Hactivism**

Many attribute it as online extremism where individuals without authorised permission breach the security of a nation, company, banks, or security agencies. This breaching leads to getting unauthorised access to classified documents and sometimes money/bonds. When the same act is done against one's own country, then it is termed as online extremism but if done in favour then called ethical hacking.

Online users resort to hacking for different purposes. They are also known as hacktivists (hack + activist) or cyber terrorists. There are instances of the army of one country/terrorist organisation hacking the sites and security sites of other countries. Some enthusiastic hackers went into the government database to show that personal details which are private data of a person uploaded by the government are not secure. Many times people from neighbouring countries hack the sites of each other and put the flag of his/her country to humiliate the other. Online hacking mainly threatens the stability of a country, institutions, etc. and the cordial relations among the two countries.

- iii. **Passive Activism/ Slacktivism/ Clicktivism Online Activism**

Passive activism means when people talk and discuss some issues on different social media platforms, but no real change is visible on the ground level. It is a passive form of resistance where people criticise government decisions, policies, or systems by being at home without facing the real situation and going through its direct effects.

There is much criticism for this type of activism. Many attributes that at least communication is going on but many questions its motive; yet there are some instances of it leading to political changes. The main criticism comes about the youth and urban middle class who are using these social

media platforms and are tech-savvy. It is said that the middle class is revolution averse. Although they talk about change in the capitalist world, post-LPG (Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation) of the 1990s but they are not interested in changing the ground reality.

iv. Mind Influencers/Alters (Viral Content Production)

Many times videos, memes, posts in support of some views are generated to reach larger masses in order to influence their mind/ attitude/behaviour. In such cases, those contents become viral and are consumed by a massive number of people. Here the propagandist views with hidden facts/fake news are shared to serve one's interest/ influence action in a particular context. It is used mainly for malafide intentions and results in negative consequences.

- v. Cyberbullying/Trolling We all are aware of cyberbullying and trolling in the present world of viral/hashtag culture. Social media not only provides a platform for activism but also allows bullies to target those whom they dislike or they find something which does not go with their taste, culture, ideals, ideology, and beliefs. Troll, in essence, means someone who leaves an intentionally annoying message on the Internet, in order to get attention or cause trouble. Through social media, not only voices can be amplified, but the same voices can be targeted by the people who think contrary to you. On many occasions, this bullying becomes abusive and to such an extent that a person is intentionally trolled for everything they do.
- vi. Social-media Campaigning, Virtual Sit-ins Marcela A. Fuentes talks about virtual sit-ins which are a form of online demonstration in which a networked community gathers on one or several sites to carry out an act of digital dissent. The action is undertaken through a web-based program that sends repetitive requests to the targeted web pages. The protesters' automated 'clickings,' simultaneously enacted from multiple computers around the world, provoke such an excess of traffic that the targeted site's server is unable to handle it. By clogging the bandwidth, the action slows down the site and eventually causes it to shut down.

14.5.2 Tools of Online Activism

With the rapid growth and evolution of technology, the list of tools keep on changing. Some of the existing tools are mentioned below:

Websites/Online Petitions: Some websites act as a hub of online activism.

Here people can communicate about their cause which by default reaches world audience.

Social Networks and Microblogging Sites: Facebook, YouTube, Twitter and many more have proven beneficial in spreading messages and garnering support. These sites bring the public's attention on a subject that mainstream media might not focus on. Some of the ways adopted for online activism using this tool are Page Likes, Sharing, and Subscription; different ways of showing solidarity and dissent (like changing profile picture or cover photo);

cartoons/screenshots/sarcastic comments/status; and live streaming. There are Groups/Forums/Event Pages, here people of the same interest come together and discuss the issues in detail.

Also, Twitter's hashtag function (#) allows people to make their tweets available for multi-user conversation. It is facilitated by a keyword or phrase preceded by a hashtag.

Blogs: Blogs are an online diary. It is a form of citizen journalism providing an effective means of communication to the masses pertaining to any topic. It has been used in many online campaigns.

Mobile Phones and Apps: A UK Uncut activist created a tool, Sukey. Sukey's combination of Google maps and Swift river (real-time data verifying service from Ushahidi Inc.) provided an avenue for the protesters to follow the action in the UK. Users could use Sukey on a browser-based tool called 'Roar,' or through SMS service 'Growl.' The Ushahidi software was used to plot activity in disaster zones like earthquakes in Haiti and New Zealand and floods in Australia and the USA.

Some other examples are Off-the-Record Messaging (OTR) software and Crabgrass.

Web Proxy Servers. Online protesters use proxy servers for avoiding government interventions on online activism. These servers are the intermediaries between a user and a site that protects the user from being identified.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Who is a Troll?

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2. Hacktivism means

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14.6 ONLINE ACTIVISM AND SOCIAL CHANGE

Online activism started in different countries at different points in time. Some of the relevant cases of online activism from across the world and Indian cases are put in the form of a table below

14.6.1 Global Trends

Name of the Country	Name of the Movement	Context	Year
Columbia	One Million voices against FARC	The most massive protest organised with the help of Facebook in 2008 against anti-terrorism, particularly against the FARC, the Colombian guerrilla group.	2008
Middle East	Arab Spring Movement	Anti-government protests drive against the government's repressive, authoritarian nature, etc.	2010
United States of America	Protests in Seattle against the WTO	Move On.org and the use of email by protesters organised protests in Seattle against the WTO in 1999. Virtual activism continued and increased during the decade of the 2000s with protests against immigration policies, terrorist groups, education cuts, and authoritarianism.	1999
	Occupy Wall Street	Peaceful occupation of Wall Street to protest against corporate influence on democracy in the US. People came on the streets.	2011
	#Black Out Sopa	To protest against the Stop Online Piracy Act, which was introduced in October 2011?	2012
	#Black lives matter	To raise consciousness about anti-black racism and police violence. A social calling card for social justice and racial equality activists across the US	2013
	#Ice bucket challenge	To promote awareness about Amyotrophic Lateral Sclerosis (ALS) and raise donations for research.	2014

	#I Stand With Ahmed	14-year-old Ahmed Mohamed was arrested for taking a homemade clock to school. A symbol for the issue of American islamophobia. Show of support using the hashtag, it included President Barack Obama also. Ahmed was invited to visit Facebook and offered a scholarship to MIT and an internship at Twitter.	2015
	#Marriage Equality	Ireland and the US legalising same-sex marriage. People took to social media to celebrate. #Pride rainbow flag and #LoveWins rainbow heart emojis; #LoveWins was used.	2015
	#unfair and lovely	Against colourism.	2016
Taiwan	Taiwan Student's Protest	Students occupy parliament buildings in Taipei, Taiwan to protest against their government trade pact with China. They used a newly released app called FireChat, through which messages can be sent from one phone to another even without an Internet connection.	2014
Nigeria	#Bring Back Our Girls	Around 276 schoolgirls were abducted by Boko Haram in the northern Nigerian village in April 2014.	2014
France	#Paris Attacks, #Pray For Paris & #JeSuis Charlie	Two major terrorist attacks in Paris. Social media users expressed their support. News Feeds were flashed with profile pictures featuring the French flag or the Eiffel Tower peace symbol drawing.	2015
Iran	#Love Beyond Flags	Trump travel ban When US President Trump put a travel ban on the seven Muslim majority nations. Iranians started a social media campaign with the hashtag 'Love Beyond Flags' on social media and shared their messages.	2017
India	Nirbhaya Movement	A girl was brutally raped in a moving bus and thrown on the streets in New	2012

		Delhi. Later she succumbed to death.	
	Anna Hazare Movement	People shared posts to organise mass agitation on streets against corruption. It forced the government to pass the Jan Lokpal bill.	2014
	#Lahu Ka Lagaan	She Says, a women's rights organisation, launched the campaign '#Lahu Ka Lagaan' to make sanitary napkins easily accessible and tax-free. The effect of this campaign led to a filing of PIL before the Bombay High Court.	2017
	#Not In My Name	To voice against the lynching of Muslims and Dalits in India, initiated by Saba Dewan (film-maker). People participated in a silent protest rally pan India.	2017
	#Me Too	First started in 2006 by an activist Tarana Burke, it went viral in 2017 after actress Alyssa Milano tweeted. In India Bollywood actress Tanushree Dutta's revelation gave it a boost in 2018. Basically, to encourage women to speak up against sexual harassment and assaults.	2017/2018
Burma	Support the Monk's Protest	The monks challenged the Junta. Biggest demonstration against the ruling military in Burma.	2007
Canada	People's Climate Movement (PCM)	Movement To unite and draw broader public attention to climate issues.	2014

This list is not exhaustive. The learners can go on adding as many cases as possible of online activism from different parts of the world.

14.6.2 Indian Trends

Some cases from India related to online activism are discussed briefly here. Few prominent cases India Against Corruption, the Nirbhaya case, and the MeToo case, are mentioned below:

India Against Corruption

Due to the support of people from all over India and netizens sharing posts to arrange mass agitation on streets, it forced the government to pass the Lokpal

Bill within the stipulated time. This movement was influenced by the Arab Spring.

Nirbhaya Case and Women Issues

In New Delhi in 2012, a heinous crime was committed where a young woman was raped in a moving bus, later she succumbed to death, which led to a burst of public outrage, and people came on the streets against the crime. Social media mainly Facebook and Twitter, built solidarity for the issue. There were protest marches on the streets of New Delhi and around the country. Moreover, a hashtag campaign in the name of #Nirbhaya, #Damini & other names were promoted. People even changed their profile picture into black as a mark of protest. This protest forced the government to frame a new law for the protection of women, and stringent punishment was put in for the heinous crime of rape committed against women.

Since this incident, many women related issues have been raised on the online medium following the trend of giving voices to women who do not normally gets adequate space in the mainstream media.

MeToo Campaign

The MeToo campaign is the social media movement where women came out and narrated their stories of sexual harassment and exploitation by the men in power. They challenged the patriarchal structure of the society and publicly humiliated and shamed people who dishonoured them in the past. The 'MeToo Movement' was started by the social activist Tarana Burke in the year 2006. It took centre stage of world glare when the Harvey Weinstein Scandal happened in the USA.

In India, this movement picked up when Bollywood actress Tanushree Dutta accused her male co-star. She went on to say that the MeToo campaign would not take shape in India as we do not have a structure supporting women. Also, this incident prompted other women to come out narrating their own #MeToo stories.

Activity- 2

Find out the usage of online/social media for a social movement and its impact. How was the media used to describe its positive and negative impact?

14.7 LET US SUM UP

We have understood the concept of activism and how people come together to question and challenge authority. Furthermore, when the online medium is used to connect to a networked world to do the same, it is known as Online Activism. We have also discussed some terms used for online activism like Media Activism, Citizen Journalism, Digital Activism, or Cyber Activism. Further, we briefly underlined the historiography of activism on the digital platform. In doing so, we have referred to the movements led in the USA,

Canada, Burma, Columbia, China, India, Egypt, and Syria. We have further elaborated on the significance of online activism in the present times when the world has become a global village and through this networked world and seen how people respond, connect and support each other on issues of global and human significance. We discussed the characteristics, tools, and types of online activism. Also, the distinction between online and offline activism was made. Some of the cases from India were briefly discussed like India against Corruption, Nirbhaya Case, and the MeToo campaign. Although this platform is limited to a small computer literate, a technology savvy young lot has its potential when we see its reach extend to a larger population transcending geographical boundaries and time separations.

14.8 KEYWORDS

Activism: Field-based actionable efforts on specific issues are called activism - environmental activism, climate change activism, political activism, etc. are some of the popular examples.

Campaign: It is a series of planned activities to achieve intended objectives. The campaign is actively pursued by a group of people or a group of organisations for more extended periods of time to meet their desired goals. Political parties, non-governmental organisations and civil society members, and groups in specific areas usually undertake campaigns in their respective fields.

Social Movements: Large numbers of people take part in a protest for the change or implementation of social change or political issues. Usually, the individuals involved in this kind movements are loosely connected, however recently in the advent of social media, the collaboration made more beneficial to the collective efforts as well as many organisations have got the opportunity to mobilise the public opinion in favour or against the change or implementation of social or political matters.

Trending Culture: Any person/issue/event which is popular among the people, mainly social media users. One which everyone talks about.

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14.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress: 1

1. Guobin Yang (2009) explains that “In online activism, most common forms include online petitions, the hosting of campaign websites, and large-scale verbal protests.” He further elaborates that “the most radical form is the hacking of websites. These forms of contention may be found in blogs, Internet bulletin boards, online communities, and podcasts and YouTube-type websites.”
2. News and its content would be directed by the audience towards what they want to see and the issues they want to address. Allen Rusbridger explains that with this new technology, now the bottom to-top approach would come where news and its content would be directed by the audience what they want to see and the issues they want to address. He gave the example of The Guardian, where first the news provider floats an issue for the netizens to react and give their responses. Accordingly, then the newspaper takes up that issue for transmission. So, there comes an almost opposite model from top-to bottom to a bottom-up approach.

Check Your Progress: 2

1. A troll is someone who leaves an intentionally annoying message on the Internet, in order to get attention or cause trouble. We all are aware of cyber bullying and trolling in the present world of viral/ hash tag culture. Social media not only provides a platform for activism but also allows bullies to target those whom they dislike or they find something which does not go with their taste, culture, ideals, ideology, and beliefs. Troll, in essence, means someone who leaves an intentionally annoying message on the Internet, in order to get attention or cause trouble or a message that someone leaves on the Internet that is intended to annoy people.
2. Online extremism where individuals without authorised permission breach the security of a nation, company, banks, or security agencies are leading to getting the unauthorised access to classified documents. When the same act is done against one’s own country, then it is termed as Online Extremism but if done in favour then called ethical hacking.

UNIT 15 ICT FOR ODL

Structure

- 15.0 Introduction
- 15.1 Learning Outcomes
- 15.2 Using Technologies in ODL
- 15.3 Generations of ODL and Technology Integration
- 15.4 ICT Integration in ODL
 - 15.4.1 ICTs in Supplementary Role in ODL
 - 15.4.2 ICTs in Complementary Role in ODL
 - 15.4.3 Integration of ICT
 - 15.4.3.1 Model of ICT Integration
- 15.5 Present Practices
 - 15.5.1 Teleconferencing and Radio Conferencing
 - 15.5.2 Online Web-Support
 - 15.5.3 Social Media Blending
 - 15.5.4 App Based Support
 - 15.5.5 SWAYAMPRAKASHA
 - 15.5.6 MOOCs including SWAYAM
- 15.6 ICT for Administrative Support
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 - 15.6.2 Database Management Using ERP
 - 15.6.3 ICTs for Assessment and Evaluation
- 15.7 Future prospects
 - 15.7.1 Badges and Credit Bank
 - 15.7.2 Rolling Admissions
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 - 15.7.5 AR and VR
 - 15.7.6 Blockchain in Higher Education
- 15.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 15.9 References and Further Readings
- 15.10 Check your Progress: Possible Answer

15.0 INTRODUCTION

Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs) have integrated up-to a large extent in today's education. From school education to higher education, everywhere ICTs have their interference and utility in formal as well as non-formal systems in education. Open and Distance learning (ODL) has also

grown a lot along with growth in ICTs and has moved towards ODeL (Open and Distance e-Learning). Present unit is an attempt to highlight the growth and development of Open and Distance learning (ODL) system along with ICTs as well as ways of ICT integration in ODL. The unit will not only reflect on recent practices of ICT integration in ODL but also discusses future perspectives of technology integration.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completion of the unit, you will be able to:

- identify role of various technologies in open and distance learning,
- enlist the transformational shifts in technologies across the generations of ODL;
- compare various models of ICT integration in ODL;
- examine the effectiveness of present ICT practices in ODL; and
- predict the future of ODL with increasing ICT intervention.

15.2 USING TECHNOLOGIES IN ODL

Open and Distance learning (ODL) has gone through various transformations since its inception. The initial model of correspondence education in early 60s was entirely different from current ICT driven model. If you go through various generations of ODL, you will yourself make a conclusion that how ICT interventions has forced ODL to change itself and walk with technology. Due to greater flexibility in pedagogy, mode of delivery and inclusive nature of ODL, adaption to the emerging ICT interventions is comparatively easier here. As ODL deals with education of masses, it also opens opportunity to use variety of media and technology. If you go through various aspects of ODL system, you will see that technology in ODL is not only limited to delivery of content or increasing interaction with learners but also it is playing equally important role in various support services, examination, governance, etc. In the coming sections of the Unit, you will get an opportunity to explore all such aspects of ODL, where technology has made its place and also has a window to adopt with future technologies.

15.3 GENERATIONS OF ODL AND TECHNOLOGY INTEGRATION

In order to understand the growth and development of Open and Distance learning (ODL) system along with the ways through which, technology has been integrated in ODL, you need to explore the generation of ODL suggested by various practitioners. Generations of ODL has been suggested in three main perspectives, i.e., technology perspective, pedagogical perspective and organizational perspective (Aoki, 2012). In present unit, the focus will remain on technological perspective only.

You all will agree that the term ‘distance’ (used in initial days of ODL) has been replaced and being dominated by the term ‘Open’ now as it gives

openness, flexibility and has filled the gap between teacher and learner using technology. Earlier discussions like Peters (1994) have talked about three generations of ODL. This was the era before web 2.0. in such discussions, first generation was referred to the traditional correspondence education, where the printed text was being delivered to learners using postal services, followed by face-to-face examination. There was hardly any teacher/tutor intervention. With the emergence of radio and television, the second generation was started where print had remained the main medium of deliver along with some supportive role of instructions through radio and television.

If we keep the impact of technology interventions in our mind, the two classifications suggested by Taylor (2001) and Moore and Kearsley (2005) seem more appropriate to discuss.

Generations of ODL as suggested by Taylor (2001)

Taylor (2001) in his article 'Fifth generation of distance education' suggested five generations of open and distance learning.

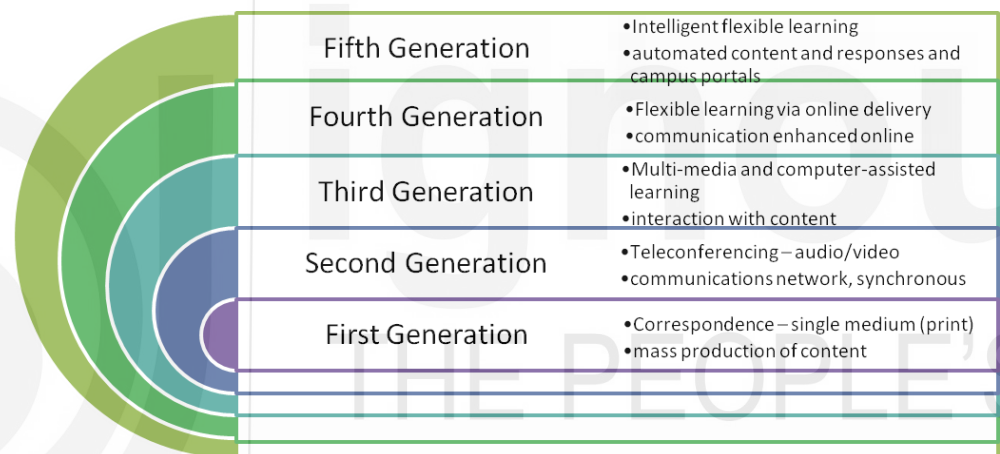


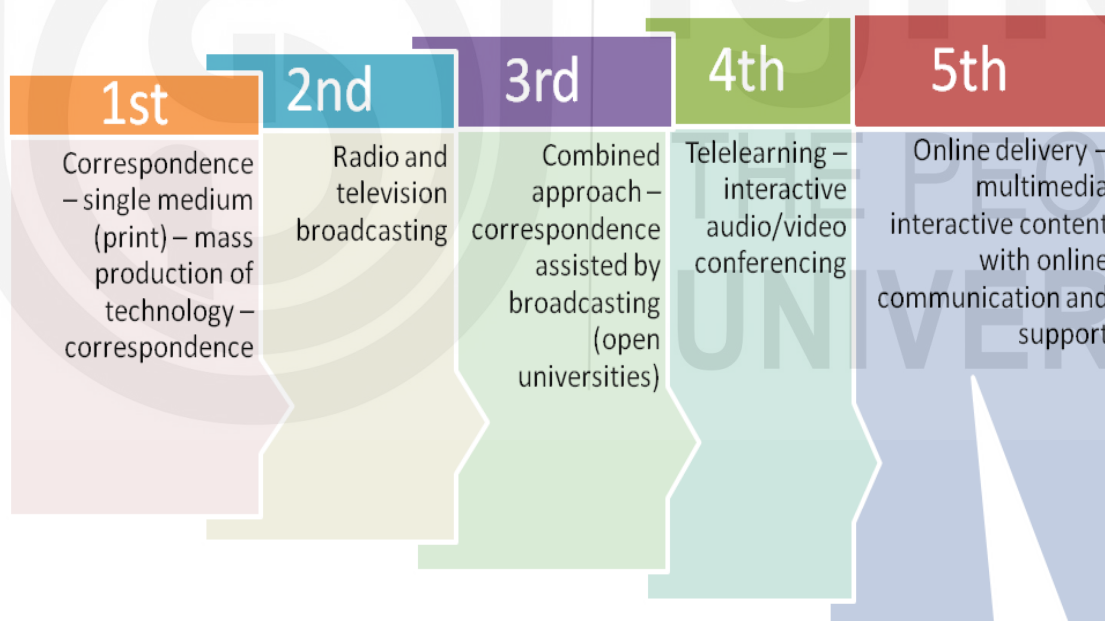
Figure 15.1: Generation of ODL (Tylor, 2001)

- The classification suggested by Tylor has suggested that in **First Generation** of ODL, the Print Self-learning Material was the medium of instruction. Learners were using Print technology to read the content and there was no/minimal opportunity for any interaction between learner and teacher. This was the time, when term 'correspondence education' was more popular. Dedicated open universities had not emerged and many dual mode institutions/universities were in operations.
- With the entry of radio and televisions, **Second Generation** of ODL has started, where a shift from 'Correspondence' to 'Distance' education has been observed. With the experiments of using radio and television for education purpose, technology integration as touched a new high. Though, most of the time, role oof radio and television remained complementary or supplementary in most of the cases. Interaction with learners have started through counselling using these media, also the curriculum based recorded programmes were broadcasted/telecasted.
- The Third Generation of ICTintegration belongs to infusion of computer-based education in ODL. Computer assisted learning (CAL) packages,

using multi-media, CD-ROM, etc. has started to integrate with traditional print-based material along with radio/television. The television also moved from terrestrial to satellite based telecast in this generation, which opened new avenues and better reach was possible with it.

- With the advancement of web 2.0 tools, interactivity increases in the Fourth Generation of ODL. Online delivery of content started in this generation, Online interactivity, two-way communication between teacher and learner were key features of this generation. Another shift in this generation was that ICT has reached deeper and its role from complimentary/supplementary has changed to ICT based material.
- The Fifth Generation has seen a lot of influence of intelligent learning solution. Online courses have started in this generation. Audio/video and e-text, all were available at same place at dedicated web-space. Open education resources (OER) movement has started. Use of social-media to increase the interactivity and in support-services has started.

If you go through above discussion, you can easily find out that how technology integration has influenced the growth and development of ODL in every generation. If you read literature, you may find many other classifications of the generations too. One such was proposed by Moore and Kearsley (2005). Here is its brief diagrammatic representation:



Source: Heydenrych and Prinsloo (2010)

Figure 15.2: Generations of ODL (Moore and Kearsley, 2005)

This discussion about use of ICT in ODL through different generation will help you to understand it that how with the advancement of technology, models of integrating technology in ODL has also grown up. After discussing about various generations of ODL with respect to ICT integration, it seems imperative, if we discuss about the ways through with ICT has been integrated in ODL.

Check Your Progress: 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for your Answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. Technology for interaction was introduced in which generation of ODL?

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2. What changes web 2.0 has brought in ODL system?

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15.4 ICT INTEGRATION IN ODL

When you will try to analyze the ways in which ICT has been used with Open and Distance Learning, you will find that it has changed with time. Initially it was supplementary, later it become complimentary, then integrated and now Online. In other words, you can say that initially there were ICT supplemented practices, later these become ICT supported followed by ICT mediated and now a days, we are witnessing ICT driven ODL practices. Let us discuss these, one by one.

15.4.1 ICTs in Supplementary Role in ODL

If you go through the initial practices, where ICTs were used in ODL, you will find that ICTs were not the part of core curriculum or pedagogy. Print based material was considered and self-contented and was main medium of instruction. In second generation, when Radio and Television was emerged, audio-video programmes were used to supplement the teaching-learning. For a long time, there was a standard practice to develop one or two audio/video programmes on any topic of importance from the whole course curriculum and provide these to learners for additional learning materials. Many times, even the course content in text and audio/video was similar. This was the time, when much resources in terms of programme production were not available with open universities/institutions. ICTs were also being used to supplement tutor-learning interaction in terms of radio-counselling or teleconferencing, but these practices were also additional to traditional counselling sessions at study centers.

15.4.2 ICTs in Complimentary Role in ODL

In third generation of ICT integration in ODL, practices changed. Now importance of audio/visual material and interactivity has been accepted worldwide. ICTs based learning material has become an important of pedagogy and broadcasting has become integral part of teaching-learning. Content planning has started keeping in mind the media and technology to be used, and there were experiments in ODL universities, where content developed using audio/video programmes and interaction through radio-counselling and teleconferencing have started complimenting the traditional print-based material. The chances of repetition of the content are reduced as at the time of planning, curriculum developers started planning the content to be delivered through different media, but till now the real integration was missing as audio/video and print material were delivering the designated content.

15.4.3 Integration in ODL

When you thing about integration, you need to think about how, integration is different from supplementary and complimentary role of ICTs in ODL. Integration of ICTs in ODL means the practices where ICTs have become equal partners with traditional print medium and curriculum developers started thinking, planning and integrating ICTs within curriculum and pedagogical practices.

How to integrate ICTs in teaching and learning effectively is a key concerned area. Various models of integration have been developed by various researchers and practitioners. You need to explore few important ones.

15.4.3.1 Model of ICT Integration

SAMR Model of Technology Integration

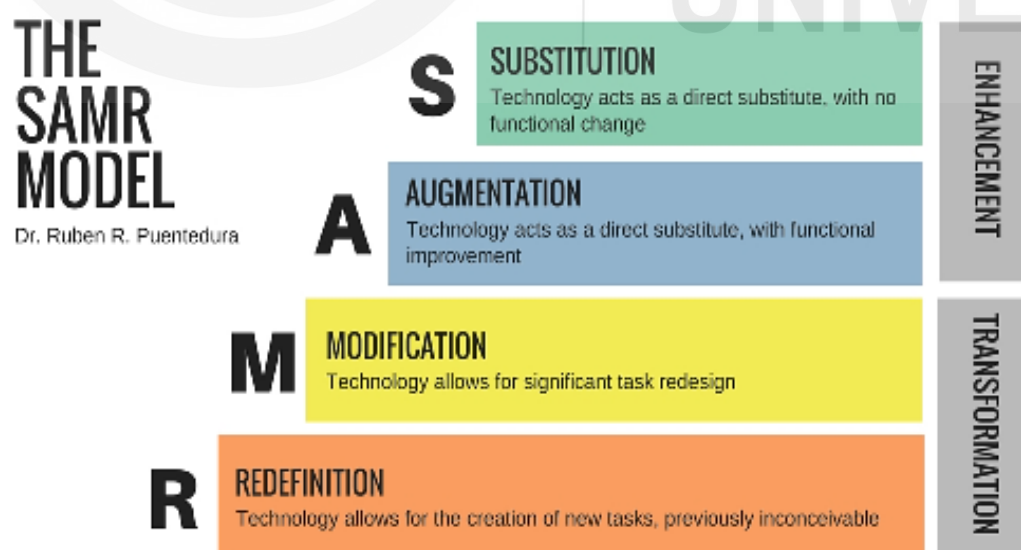


Image Credit: Lefflerd, CC BY-SA 4.0, Wikimedia Commons

Figure 15.3: SAMR Model

The SAMR framework was developed Dr. Ruben Puentedura to explain the ways of integrating technologies in teaching-learning. The letters "SAMR" stand for Substitution, Augmentation, Modification, and Redefinition, in which Substitution is the lowest level of integration and substitution is at the highest level.

Substitution

If a tutor plans to replace the traditional print-based content with any ICT based, and it emerged as a direct replacement, this comes under substitution. For example, if in a unit of ODL print material there as five important sections and unit writer replaces one or two sections with a video, audio or web link and ask learner to go through that resources. The self-check exercise and quiz is also linked with the ICT resource suggested. Sometimes, it can a word file, excel sheet or PPT also.

Augmentation

This is also a kind of direct replacement but to enhance the learning experience by augmenting technology for enhancing productivity and potential of the learner. Here learners are asked to augment their learning with various web-links, video-clips, etc. so that they can learn better.

The important point to be noted in substitution and augmentation is that the structure of design of the unit is not changed. These are to enhance learning experience. In next two levels, there is a shift from enhancement to transformation, i.e., for integrating ICTs, the whole unit/lesson design and learning outcomes also get changed.

Modification

Here, \whole design of the unit/lesson is changed along with learning outcomes keeping in mind the learners and available technology. Sometimes, learners are also given opportunity to create their own graphics, presentations, video/audio, etc based on their experiences. Modification also helps in contextualizing of the learning experiences. Sometimes, when learners are asked to present, they develop something new by using existing ICT resources and adding their own creation in it.

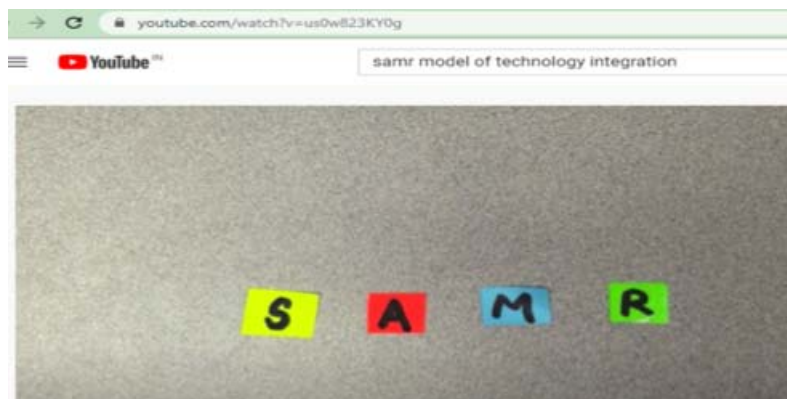
Redefinition

This is the highest level of SAMR model. This basically focus on strategies to transform learner's experiences by using technology. Curriculum planners and content developers give such a shape to the content where it seems impossible to complete the unit/lesson and tasks without using ICTs. Variety of ICTs are interwoven in the lesson design. It gives a unique learning experience to the learners. Use of verity of ICTs helps to deal learner with different learning styles andteaching-learning become more inclusive.

To read more details, following web link can be explored:

<https://sites.google.com/a/msad60.org/technology-is-learning/samr-model>

Here is one video, which can be accessed to understand the SAMR Model:



Link for the video: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=us0w823KY0g>

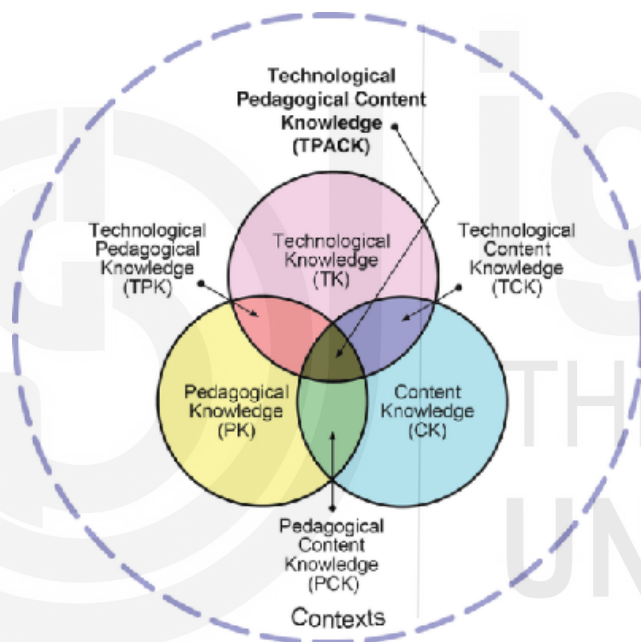


Image Credit: Matthew Koehler, CC0, via Wikimedia Commons

Figure 15.4: TPACK Model

This framework was suggested by Mishra and Koehler (2006), they added Technological Knowledge (TK) in the Pedagogical Content Knowledge (PCK) model developed by Shulman in 80s. The new framework is known as Technological Pedagogical Content Knowledge (TPCK or TPACK) framework. Mishra & Koehler (2006) define technological content knowledge (TCK) as, "... the knowledge about the manner in which technology and content are reciprocally related". It represents the knowledge required to identify and select technology tools and resources in a particular content area. TPK, in essence, is the knowledge that helps teachers to maximize a particular technology's affordances to support a pedagogical strategy or model. Mishra and Koehler (2006) describe TPACK as:

...the basis of good teaching with technology and requires an understanding of the representation of concepts using technologies; pedagogical techniques that use technologies in constructive ways to teach content; knowledge of what makes concepts difficult or easy to learn and how technology can help redress some of the problems that students face; knowledge of students' prior knowledge and theories of epistemology; and knowledge of how technologies can be used to build on existing knowledge and to develop new epistemologies or strengthen old ones (p. 1029).

This model facilitates planners and teachers to have a holistic picture of all three aspects, i.e., the Technology, pedagogy and Content and all three dimensions are planned together to give learners better learning experiences. The nature of content, appropriate pedagogy to deliver the content and best technology available to deal with the content effectively, are being planned together in this framework.

TIM: Technology Integration Matrix

LEVELS OF TECHNOLOGY INTEGRATION →	 ENTRY LEVEL The teacher begins to use technology tools to deliver curriculum content to students.	 ADOPTION LEVEL The teacher directs students in the conventional and procedural use of technology tools.	 ADAPTATION LEVEL The teacher facilitates the students' exploration and independent use of technology tools.	 INFUSION LEVEL The teacher provides the learning context and the students choose the technology tools.	 TRANSFORMATION LEVEL The teacher encourages the innovative use of technology tools to facilitate higher-order learning activities that may not be possible without the use of technology.
	CHARACTERISTICS OF THE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT ↓				
 ACTIVE LEARNING Students are actively engaged in using technology as a tool rather than passively receiving information from the technology.	 Active Entry Information passively received	 Active Adoption Conventional, procedural use of tools	 Active Adaptation Conventional independent use of tools; some student choice and exploration	 Active Infusion Choice of tools and regular, self-directed use	 Active Transformation Extensive and unconventional use of tools
 COLLABORATIVE LEARNING Students use technology tools to collaborate with others rather than working individually at all times.	 Collaborative Entry Individual student use of technology tools	 Collaborative Adoption Collaborative use of tools in conventional ways	 Collaborative Adaptation Collaborative use of tools; some student choice and exploration	 Collaborative Infusion Choice of tools and regular use for collaboration	 Collaborative Transformation Collaboration with peers, outside experts, and others in ways that may not be possible without technology
 CONSTRUCTIVE LEARNING Students use technology tools to connect new information to their prior knowledge rather than to passively receive information.	 Constructive Entry Information delivered to students	 Constructive Adoption Guided, conventional use for building knowledge	 Constructive Adaptation Independent use for building knowledge; some student choice and exploration	 Constructive Infusion Choice and regular use for building knowledge	 Constructive Transformation Extensive and unconventional use of technology tools to build knowledge
 AUTHENTIC LEARNING Students use technology tools to link learning activities to the world beyond the instructional setting rather than working on decontextualized assignments.	 Authentic Entry Technology use unrelated to the world outside of the instructional setting	 Authentic Adoption Guided use in activities with some meaningful context	 Authentic Adaptation Independent use in activities connected to students' lives; some student choice and exploration	 Authentic Infusion Choice of tools and regular use in meaningful activities	 Authentic Transformation Innovative use for higher-order learning activities connected to the world beyond the instructional setting
 GOAL-DIRECTED LEARNING Students use technology tools to set goals, plan activities, monitor progress, and evaluate results rather than simply completing assignments without reflection.	 Goal-Directed Entry Directions given; step-by-step task monitoring	 Goal-Directed Adoption Conventional and procedural use of tools to plan or monitor	 Goal-Directed Adaptation Purposeful use of tools to plan and monitor; some student choice and exploration	 Goal-Directed Infusion Flexible and seamless use of tools to plan and monitor	 Goal-Directed Transformation Extensive and higher-order use of tools to plan and monitor

Source: <https://fcit.usf.edu/matrix/tim-descriptors/>

Figure 15.5: TIM Matrix

The Technology Integration Matrix(TIM) provides a framework for describing and targeting the use of technology to enhance learning. In this model, five levels of technology integration are suggested i.e., entry, adoption, adaptation, infusion, and transformation, these levels are associated with five key interdependent characteristics, i.e., active, collaborative, constructive, authentic, and goal-directed. In order to facilitate the meaningful learning environment, these five characteristics and the five levels of technology integration create a matrix of 25 cells, as illustrated below.

This brief discussion on various models of technology integration will definitely help you in developing your understanding about technology integration takes places in teaching-learning. ODL system has also emerged with time and adopted various models as per the nature and requirement of the academic programme. In order to develop more detailed understanding about technology use in ODL system, try to examine various existing practices across the world.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for your answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the differences between supplementary and complimentary role of ICT in ODL?

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2. How does TPACK help in better planning and transactions of content in ODL?

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15.5 PRESENT PRACTICES

in order to understand the use of information communication technologies (ICTs) in open and distance learning, it is essential to know about the parties, which are there in the system. In the era of web 3.0 technologies also, the traditional blending of audio/video with print SLM or support from radio and

television has not lost its relevance yet and being used effectively to facilitate learning in ODL system. but new technologies have also emerged and being used to enhance the learning experiences of ODL learners. You can develop a fair understanding of these practices after going through the details of some of these:

15.5.1 Teleconferencing and Radio-conferencing

The use of radio and television for learner support is the key feature of ODL practices. If you see the practices in IGNOU, **Gyanvani FM Radio stations** and **DD-Gyandarshan** as a television channel have proved their worth nationwide. Millions of the students used the programmes being available through these mediums to enhance their learning. Along with recorded programme, these two platforms are being used effectively for counselling purpose also.

Teleconferencing

Teleconferencing connects electronically a number of users located at different places to interact through audio-video, or computer technology. The technology is very useful in ODL system as it links both learners and teachers for teaching-learning purpose. In teleconferencing, there are mainly teaching end and several learning ends. Teaching end is a studio with an uplink facility. In the case of Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU), the studio of Electronic Media Production Centre (EMPC) serves as the teaching end, from where programmes are being uplinked to satellite and the learning ends are centres having downlink facility/DTH with television set as well as telephone talkback system.

In the case of IGNOU, all the Regional Centres and a number of Study Centres serve as learning ends. Learners can also watch the live sessions from their home as all major DTH operators carry its Gyandarshan Channel, through which the teleconferencing sessions are reaches to them. Distance learners of IGNOU came to these learning ends and interact with the resource persons at the teaching end. IGNOU is using teleconferencing since October, 1993.





Figure 15.6: Teleconferencing at Gyandarshan

Radio Counselling

Radio is one of the most common and cheap media available in India. Though it has started as analogue technology which was operated on analogue modes using frequency modulation, but now it has also using digital technology. Message through Radio can reach to millions of people at the same time. It is also being used not only to broadcast the educational programmes for the teaching- learning purpose, but also being used with two-way communication between the teacher and learners, popularly known as interactive radio instruction or **interactive radio counselling(IRC)**. In the interactive radio counselling sessions, teachers/experts sit in the studio and learners get opportunity to interact with them using tele-calling facility, web-based interactions, etc. “IGNOU’s Gyan Vani (GV) FM Radio was conceived in 2001 as a network of educational FM Radio Channels operating from various cities in the country. With an aim to enhance and supplement the teaching-learning process, each GV Station has a range of about 60 kms and covers an entire city/town including the adjoining rural areas.” (IGNOU, 2020)

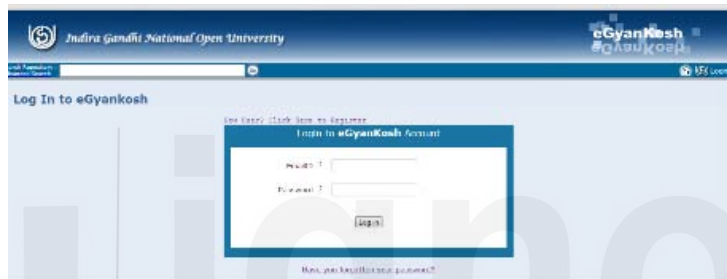


Figure 15.7: Radio-Counselling at GyanVani

15.5.2 Online Web-support

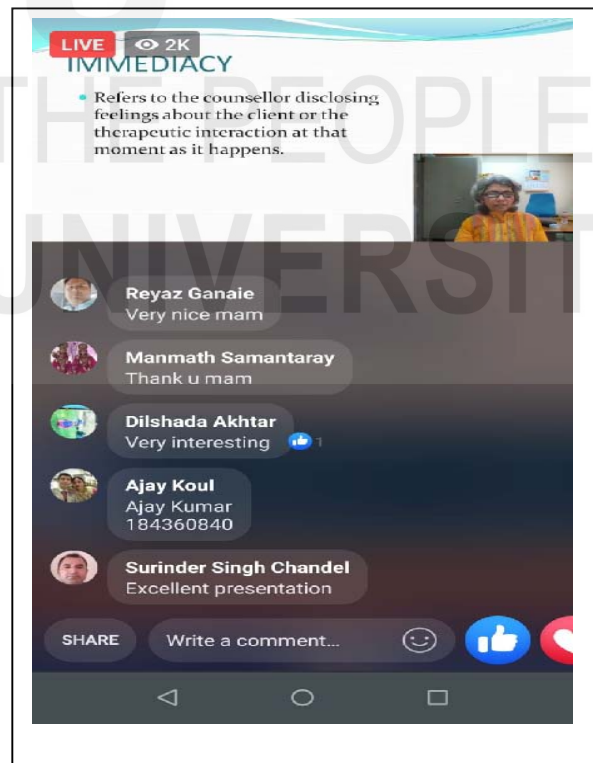
Along with traditional audio-video support, now online web support has emerged a good tool in ODL. It has decreased the gap between teacher and learners and also enhances the opportunity for greater academic interaction and administrative support. Websites, e-mails, Google Groups are there to

support the learners. The availability of learning material on repositories like e-Gyankosh, Online web-radio Gyandhara, support through chat-boats, e-conferencing, etc. are the facilities which are helping a lot to learners.



15.5.3 Social Media Blending

With the increased penetration and reach of social media among learners, its educational use has become very prominent. WhatsApp based support, Telegram groups, Facebook Live sessions, etc. are some examples, through which interaction between teachers and learners is increasing. These are helping also in reaching to learners, resolving their day-to-day issues, content support etc. Sometimes, large group of learners have been given learning support/training sessions also through these platforms.





IGNOU and many other open universities and institutions have started their app-based support also to learners. This helps learners to have 24/7 support for facilities, content etc. IGNOU has developed its student app, which facilitates learners to know about their enrollment status, assignments, grade card status, etc. Similarly, it has also developed its e-content app through which anyone can access its content available with e-Gyankosh.



5.5.5 SWAYAMPARBHA

In 2017, Government of India launched The SWAYAM PRABHA project to facilitate learning through television. At present, it is a group of 34 DTH channels devoted to telecasting of high-quality educational programmes on 24X7 basis using the GSAT-15 satellite. Every day, there will be new content for at least (4) hours which would be repeated 5 more times in a day, allowing the students to choose the time of their convenience. The channels are uplinked from BISAG, Gandhinagar. The contents are provided by NPTEL, IITs, UGC, CEC, IGNOU, NCERT and NIOS. The INFLIBNET

Centre maintains the web portal. IGNOU is also having four channels in the project and facilitating the learners of various schools of studies/disciplines. There is one channel for State Open Universities also through which all state open universities can telecast the video programmes for their learners even in regional languages. This project has a lot of potential to facilitate learners with the television base instructions.

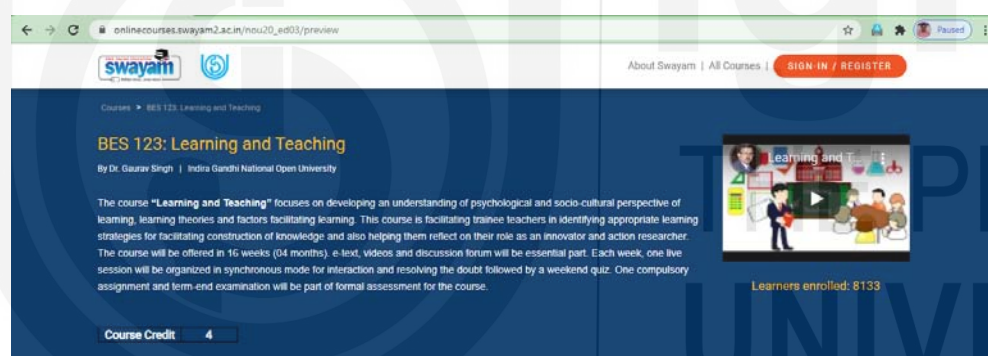


5.5.6 MOOCs including SWAYAM

MOOC is the new buzz word in educational scenario now. It stands for Massive Open Online Courses (MOOC). MOOC has not only bridged the gap between ODL and Conventional universities but also given an opportunity to learners beyond any geographical or administrative boundary to learn on will and choice. There are many popular MOOC platforms like Coursera, Edx, Futurelearn, etc. across the world and SWAYAM has emerged as Indian MOOC platform. Government of India has initiated SWAYAM in 2016 as a MOOC platform for Indian universities and institutions.

SWAYAM is designed to achieve the three cardinal principles of Education Policy viz., access, equity and quality. The objective of this effort is to take the best teaching learning resources to all, including the most disadvantaged. SWAYAM seeks to bridge the digital divide for students who have hitherto remained untouched by the digital revolution and have not been able to join the mainstream of the knowledge economy. This is done through a platform that facilitates hosting of all the courses, taught in classrooms from Class 9 till post-graduation to be accessed by anyone, anywhere at any time. All the courses are interactive, prepared by the best teachers in the country and are available, free of cost to any learner. More than 1,000 specially chosen faculty and teachers from across the country have participated in preparing these courses.

The courses hosted on SWAYAM are in 4 quadrants – (1) video lecture, (2) specially prepared reading material that can be downloaded/printed (3) self-assessment tests through tests and quizzes and (4) an online discussion forum for clearing the doubts. Steps have been taken to enrich the learning experience by using audio-video and multi-media and state of the art pedagogy / technology. In order to ensure that best quality content is produced and delivered, nine National Coordinators have been appointed. IGNOU is one of these. IGNOU has offered more than 100 courses on SWAYAM ranging from certificate to post-graduate level courses.



Many state open universities/ODL institutions have developed their own mechanism too to facilitate learners using various ICT facilities available with them.

Check Your Progress 3

Note: 1) Answer the question in the space given below.

2) Match your answers with the hints given at the end of the unit.

3. Enlist the present academic practices of use of ICT in ODL?

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4. What is the difference between SWAYAM and SWAYAMPRAKASH?

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15.6 ICT FOR ADMINISTRATIVE SUPPORT

Along with academic support in ODL institutions, ICTs are of great use for administrative support services too. This can be categorized like ICTs for e-Governance, ICTs for Examination, ICTs for material access, ICTs for networking, etc. let us examine these one by one.

15.6.1 ICT for E-Governance

When we talk about ICT in e-Governance, it involves activities like admission, record keeping, resource management, etc. In any ODL institution, there are activities like admissions in different cycles, course selection within a programme, study center allotment, maintaining records of submissions, communicating with learners/study centers and parents, generating various certificates, analyzing various data, etc. in which ICT are playing important role. In IGNOU, online admission, data management at Regional centers, examination form submission, checking status of submissions and certificate, etc. are the services which are in online mode.

The screenshot displays the IGNOU Admission Information Bulletin website. The header is purple with the IGNOU logo and navigation links: HOME, REGIONAL CENTERS, ADMISSION FAQ, PROGRAMME INFORMATION, and USER GUIDE. A search bar is located on the right. Below the header, the section 'Available Programme's' is shown. It contains eight programme cards arranged in two rows of four. Each card lists the programme name, duration, and a 'Read More' button.

Programme Name	Duration
ACISE : ADVANCE CERTIFICATE IN INFORMATION SECURITY	0 Year, 6 Months
ACPD : ADVANCED CERTIFICATE IN POWER DISTRIBUTION MANAGEMENT	0 Year, 6 Months
ACE : Appreciation Course on Environment	0 Year, 3 Months
ACPSD : Appreciation Course on Population and Sustainable Development	0 Year, 3 Months
APDF : Awareness Programme on Dairy Farming	0 Year, 2.04 Months
GST : Awareness Programme on Goods and Services Tax	0 Year, 2.04 Months
BAG : BACHELOR OF ARTS	3 Years
BTS : BACHELOR OF ARTS (TOURISM STUDIES)	3 Years

15.6.2 Database Management Using ERP

Database management in ODL institutions is an important function. Now days, 'Enterprise Resource Planning' (ERP) systems are being used for it. "ERP is an enterprise-wide information system designed to coordinate all the resources, information, and activities needed to complete all the organizational processes based on a common database and a modular

software design. (Singh, 2018)". IGNOU is using its own ERP system named ODLSoft for various operations like leave management, financial transitions, housing allotment, salary management, etc. now Government of India has also rolled out its central ERP system called "SAMARTH" for universities.



15.6.3 ICTs for Assessment and Evaluation

In most of the ODL institutions, ICTs are being used for examination for filling, allotment of examination centers, downloading admit cards, etc. But now use of ICTs has expended its horizon. Online delivery of Question papers, Online assessment of answer scripts, computer-based online entrance and term-end examination, Question bank, automated question paper generation, Learning Management System (LMS) based assessment, computer-based marking, are the areas in which ODL institutions have started moving in now.

15.7 FUTURE PROSPECTS

Till now, you must have developed a fair understanding of ever-changing face of Open and Distance Learning due to technological interventions. As many new and emerging technologies are knocking the doors of ODL, there are possibilities of inclusion of many new technologies. National Education Policy-2020 has also hinted about it and demands for experimentation on new models of teaching-learning through various institutions. Many have already started on pilot basis, many are in pipe-line. Following discussion will help to develop a basic understanding of upcoming technologies, which can be part of ODL in coming days.

15.7.1 Badges and Credit Bank

Badges and Academic Credit bank are the future of technology enabled education in future. Many open universities in world like UKOU, have already started the concept of badges. National Education Policy, 2020 in India has also advocated the establishment of Academic Bank of Credits (ABC).

Digital badges or online badges are being provided to learners on accomplishment of a particular skill, course, or attaining a level of competency. These badges generally talk about the level of proficiency of learners in a particular area. As these are given by institutions and are available for verification of employers, hence these enhances changes of

employability too. These are great tool of professional development and life-long learning. As per recommendations of NEP-2020, UGC has rolled out a plan to establish Academic Bank of Credit (ABC) with an objective to facilitate student mobility across the education system. It will bring more flexibility and openness in higher education scenario. One learner can accumulate credits from any institutions by doing a course. Once, his/her accumulated academic credits become equivalent to a diploma/degree, he/she can claim that from an institution. This will bring a new era of collaboration and learning will go beyond the boundaries of only one college/university.

15.7.2 Rolling Admissions

As the future of ODL is credit based and course-based learning will be promoted now, hence a learner may not require admission at a particular time (like January/July). A learner can join any course at any time, complete it and accumulate its credit. Choices will be there for subject domain as well as of timing. Anytime, anywhere learning, which is a moto of ODL system, will be encouraged more. This will also open the opportunity of on-demand examinations. As learner will complete a course, he/she can demand examination for that course. With the penetration of technology in examination system, it will possible to organize computer-based examination of any learner as per his/her choice.

15.7.3 Fully Online Programmes

At present, most of the online courses are either single non-credit/credit or course-based learning approach is being practices and promoted. But, in future there are possibilities to offer fully standalone online programmes with multiple courses. University Grants Commission (UGC) has already rolled out the norms of online programmes in 2020. IGNOU has started offering some programmes in fully online mode from certificate to master's level. In future, many such programmes will be on offer. Experiments are going on for programmes required hands-on or practical components too, there are possibilities for such programme also in online mode.

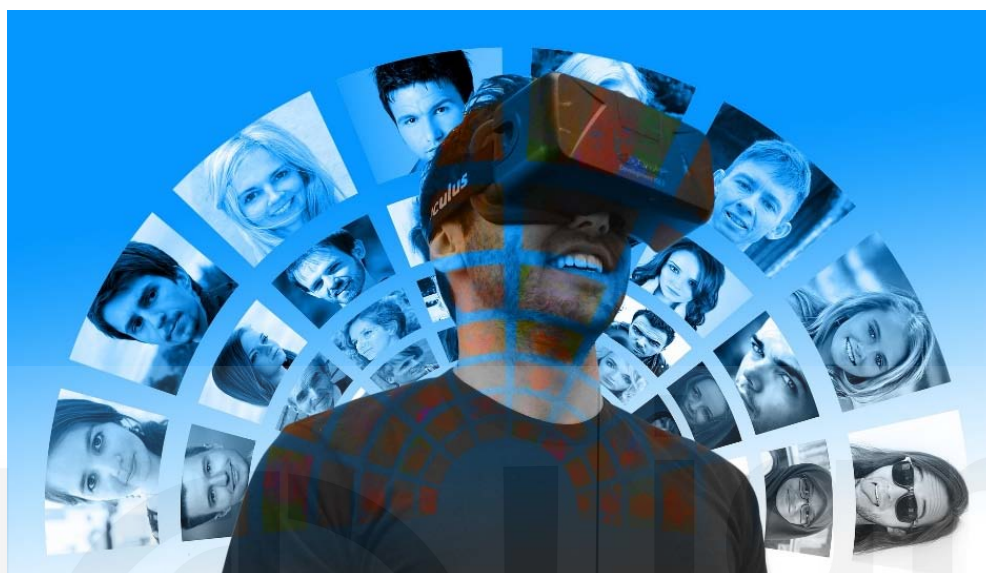
15.7.4 Online Homebased Assessment

Experiments in this new mode of examination has also started. With the use of emerging technologies, the present system of computer-based examination, in which a learner has to go toa designated place/center for examination for proctored examination is also going to change in near future. There are technologies to detect presence of any-other person in room, retina scan and eye moment, lip reading, face-recognition, room temperature change with presence of another person, etc. These technologies will be used in future for home-based online examination by integrating technologies in Artificial Intelligence (AI) based applications.

15.7.5 AR and VR

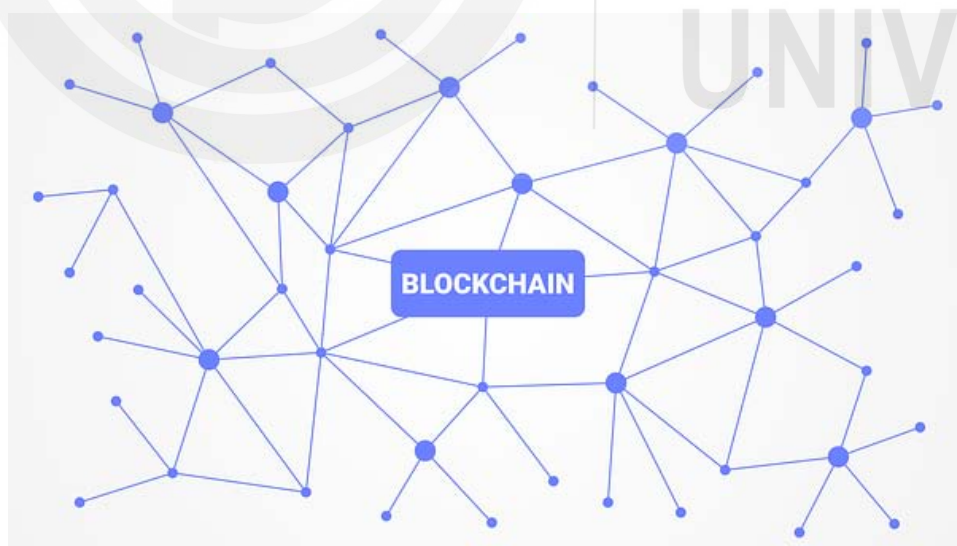
Augmented reality (AR) and Virtual Reality (VR) are the future of online education. With integration of AR/VR, the learning experiences will be

enhanced for learners. AR/VR based headsets are going to future of classroom and also in ODL at study centers. The AR/VR will enhance learning experiences of the learners. In the areas like vocational/skill based higher education, AR/VR are going to be great help. IN the fields like medical education, nursing, the use of immersive technologies has already started. Vocational training in engineering and technology, new media and arts applications are the areas, where use of AR/VR is going to be future.



15.7.6 Blockchain in Higher Education

Blockchain technology is also an emerging disruption in higher education, which have its distinct benefits in ODL. “The most promising use case for blockchain in higher education is to transform the “record keeping” of degrees, certificates and diplomas” (Moore, 2019).



There are many benefits of Blockchain in education like improving record keeping, improving employability and verification of records by employer, emerging as a new market of cloud-based storage, accumulation of badges and facilitating in earning diploma/degree, facilitating flexible and choice-based learning, reducing the cost of record generation, keeping and precurring, etc.

Check Your Progress

- Note:** 1) Answer the question in the space given below.
2) Match your answers with the hints given at the end of the unit.
5. Explore internet and find out the emerging technologies which can be used in ODL in near future.

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15.8 LET US SUM UP

Unit has started with a discussion on role of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) for Open and Distance Learning (ODL) systems. ICT interventions has force ODL to change itself and walk with technology. Discussion moved towards Generations of ODL, which have been suggested in three main perspectives, i.e., technology perspective, pedagogical perspective and organizational perspective. Unit has discussed in details mainly two classifications of generations suggested by Tylor (2001) and Moore and Kearsley (2005). How ICTs have been integrated in the ODL, this was also discussed in progressive manner. Modes of ICT integration from supplementary to complimentary to true integration have been discussed. Some models of ICT integration like SMAR, TPACK and SIM Matrix were discussed in the unit to give you an understanding of ways, in which ICT integration can help in teaching-learning to ODL learners. Unit has highlighted various present practices like teleconferencing, radio-conferencing, web support, SWAYAM and SWAYAMPRAKHA, also in brief. ICTs are being used only for academic support but also for administrative support in ODL. Role of ICTs in resource management, financial management, examination, etc., have been discussed in the unit. At the end of the unit, future possibilities of using ICTs in ODL have also been discussed in brief.

15.9 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

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15.10 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWER

1. Interactive technologies were introduced in third generation of ODL.
2. Answer the question based on your understanding developed after reading section 14.4.
3. In supplementary role, ICTs are used to supplement the teaching-learning on ODL which is mainly through print based material. If a learner does not use the ICT support, he/she is not at loss on any content whereas in complimentary role, use of ICTs is planned in a way that content developed using audio/video programmes and interaction through radio-counselling and teleconferencing have started complimenting the traditional print-based material.
4. Answer based on your understanding developed while reading about the framework.
5. Enlist on the basis of discussion help in section 14.6.
6. SWAYAM is an online learning portal on which various institutions offer online MOOC courses for learner whereas SWAYAMPRAKASH is a bouquet of 34 DTH television channels to support teaching-learning.
7. Explore internet and write the answer.

